

CHAPTER 1: NORTH DAKOTA (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: EARTH-10005 (PRESENT DAY)****

****LOCATION: THE GRAVE OF JAMES HOWLETT****

The cold wasn't just a temperature. It was a texture.

It was a physical weight, pressing down on the North Dakota forest like a woolen blanket soaked in liquid nitrogen. It didn't just sit on the skin; it hunted. It sought out the weak points in my suit—the microscopic gaps in the stitching, the places where the spandex had thinned from friction—and it bit down with teeth made of wind shear.

I stood over the grave.

My breath didn't just fog; it crystallized. Tiny, jagged diamonds of moisture expelled from my lungs, freezing instantly in the air before drifting down to join the millions of other frozen breaths that made up this winter.

I am a popsicle, the voice in my head whispered. *I am a flavor of ice cream that nobody ordered. Cherry-red and regret-flavored.*

I adjusted my grip on the shovel. It was a cheap thing, bought from a hardware store three timelines over. The handle was ash wood, varnished to a shine that was already cracking under the thermal stress.

"Okay, Wolvie," I whispered. My voice sounded small, swallowed instantly by the vast, indifferent acoustics of the forest. "Don't be shy."

I looked at the ground.

It wasn't dirt. It was concrete made of soil. Permafrost. The earth here had frozen solid a thousand years ago and hadn't thawed since. It was a vault. A bank safe. And I was trying to break in with a gardening tool.

I raised the shovel.

Physics check. Mass times acceleration equals force. Force divided by the resistance of frozen mud equals... pain.

I brought it down.

THWACK.

The sound was obscene. It was the sound of a bone breaking under a heavy cloth.

The shockwave traveled up the wooden handle, bypassing my gloves, and slammed into the bones of my forearms. My radius and ulna vibrated like tuning forks.

"Motherfluffer," I hissed.

I looked at the ground. I had made a scratch. A tiny, insignificant white line in the dark earth.

This is going to take a while.

I swung again. And again. And again.

Thwack. Thwack. Crunch.

The rhythm took over.

Digging is a conversation between your muscles and the earth. And right now, the earth was winning.

My shoulders burned. The deltoids were screaming, filling with lactic acid that felt like battery fluid. My lats were tight cables of agony. But then... the heat.

The Healing Factor.

It kicked in. I could feel it. It was a biological hum, a swarm of microscopic bees working under my skin. It found the torn muscle fibers—the micro-traumas caused by the exertion—and it stitched them back together.

It wasn't pleasant. It was an itch I couldn't scratch. It was the sensation of pins and needles, dialed up to eleven.

Dig. Tear. Heal. Dig. Tear. Heal.

I was a machine of perpetual motion, fueled by self-repair and desperation.

The hole got deeper.

Six inches. A foot. Two feet.

The smell changed.

Topsoil smells like pine needles and squirrel shit. It's organic. Alive.

But deeper?

The layer below the frost line smelled different. It smelled of clay. Of wet slate. Of time. It was a heavy, mineral scent that coated the back of my throat and tasted like sucking on a penny.

"You're in there deep, aren't you, peanut?" I panted. Sweat was running down my back, freezing before it hit my waistband.

My shovel hit something.

CLANG.

It wasn't the dull thud of a rock. It was the ringing, high-pitched note of metal.

I stopped.

I dropped to my knees. The cold bit through the knees of my suit, instantly numbing my skin. I didn't care.

I clawed at the dirt with my gloved hands. I brushed away the frozen clumps of soil.

There it was.

The box.

It wasn't a coffin. Coffins are wood. They are polite. They decompose.

This was a crate. A shipping container for a soul.

It was made of an alloy that didn't rust, but it had tarnished. It was a dull, gunmetal grey, scarred by the weight of the earth pressing on it for years.

I ran my hand over the lid. It was cold enough to burn.

"Wakey wakey," I whispered. "Eggs and bakey."

I grabbed the edge of the lid.

I pulled.

It didn't budge. The hinges were fused. Time and pressure had welded them shut.

"Okay," I said. "Maximum Effort."

I planted my feet. I braced my back. I gripped the metal until my gloves creaked.

I pulled.

My biceps bulged. My triceps flared. I could feel the tendons in my neck popping, snapping like rubber bands, then instantly knitting back together. The pain was blinding. White hot stars danced in my vision.

SCREEEEEEEEEEEE.

The sound was deafening. Metal shearing against metal. It sounded like a train braking on a track made of chalkboards. It was a sound that made your teeth ache.

The lid gave. Just an inch.

The smell hit me then.

I expected rot. I expected the sweet, cloying scent of decomposition.

But there was nothing.

Just... dust. Dry, sterile dust.

He didn't rot, I realized. *He desiccated.*

I threw the lid back. It slammed into the dirt with a heavy *thud*.

I looked inside.

The world narrowed down to the rectangle of the box. The forest, the snow, the cold—it all faded.

There was only the skeleton.

It was... beautiful.

I know, I know. That sounds morbid. Like I'm writing poetry for a goth girl in 2004. But it was.

It wasn't white. Bone is white. This was silver.

It was polished. Gleaming. Even in the dim light of the moon, it shone with an inner luminescence. The Adamantium.

It coated every inch of him. Every rib was a silver arch. The femur was a chrome pillar. The skull...

I stared at the skull.

It was a masterpiece of engineering. The eye sockets were deep, shadowed pools. The jaw was set in a permanent, metallic grin.

He died screaming, the voice whispered. *Look at the jaw. It's unhinged. He died in pain.*

"No," I whispered. "No, no, no."

I reached out. I touched the skull.

It was smooth. frictionless. My finger slid over the brow ridge.

"You're dead," I said. The words felt heavy in my mouth, like stones. "You're actually dead."

I tapped the metal. *Tink. Tink.*

"I thought... I thought it was a metaphor," I said to the bones. "I thought you were just... sleeping. Healing. Taking a really long, dirt-nap."

I poked a rib.

"Regenerate!" I commanded. "Come on! Pop a claw! Heal! Do the thing!"

Nothing.

Just the silence of the grave. Just the wind whistling through the empty ribcage like a flute made of a superhero.

I sat back. I sat right in the mud.

The realization hit me not as a thought, but as a physical sensation. A hollowing out of my chest.

He's gone. The Anchor is gone. My world is gone.

"Freeze!"

The voice shattered the moment.

It came from everywhere. Amplified. Distorted by a megaphone.

I looked up.

They were standing on the rim of the clearing. Twelve of them.

TVA Minutemen.

Their armor was black, matte, absorbing the moonlight. Their helmets were faceless ovals of orange glass.

They held batons. Pruning sticks.

The tips glowed with a violent, violet energy. It hummed. *Vvvvvvm. Vvvvvvm.* It sounded like a nest of angry hornets.

"Wade Wilson," the lead agent said. His voice was tinny, filtered through a speaker. "Step away from the deceased Variant."

I looked at them. I looked at the box.

Analysis:

* **Threat Level:** High. Those sticks erase you from existence.

* **Escape Route:** None. Surrounded.

* **Weaponry:** I have a shovel. They have god-tech.

I stood up. My knees popped.

"You guys," I said. "You have terrible timing. I'm having a moment here. A *Hamlet* moment. 'Alas, poor Logan! I knew him, Horatio!'"

I picked up the skull. I held it aloft.

"He was a fellow of infinite jest! Okay, mostly infinite grumpiness. But still."

"Drop the artifact," the agent ordered. "Hands on your head. Prepare for extraction."

"Extraction?" I laughed. It was a brittle, sharp sound. "Sounds like dentistry. And I hate dentists. They always ask you questions when your mouth is full of fingers."

I looked at the skeleton.

I need a weapon.

I looked at the femur.

The leg bone. The longest bone in the body. Coated in the strongest metal in the universe.

It's a bat. A very expensive, very heavy baseball bat.

"Sorry, peanut," I whispered to the skull. "I'm gonna need to borrow your legs. I promise I'll bring them back. Mostly."

I reached down. I grabbed the femur.

It was heavy. Denser than lead. It felt like holding a solid bar of gold.

I ripped it free. The connective tissue—dried, dusty tendons—snapped with a sound like tearing parchment.

"Prune him," the agent said.

The Minutemen advanced.

Time slows down.

Adrenaline is a hell of a drug. It floods the system. The world sharpened.

I saw the individual snowflakes drifting down.

I saw the condensation on the agent's visor.

I saw the exact arc of the first baton swinging toward my head.

"Music," I whispered. "I need a beat."

BYE BYE BYE.

The beat dropped in my head.

I moved.

Beat 1: The Windup.

I planted my left foot. I twisted my hips. I swung the femur like I was aiming for the fences at Yankee Stadium.

The air *whooshed*.

Beat 2: The Impact.

The bone connected with the agent's helmet.

CRACK.

It wasn't a clean sound. It was messy. Wet.

The helmet didn't just break; it shattered. The visor exploded into a thousand shards of orange glass.

The force of the blow was transferred instantly into the agent's neck. I saw the whiplash. I heard the vertebrae snapping like dry twigs.

Beat 3: The Follow-Through.

The agent flew. Literally flew. He hit a tree ten feet away. *THUD.* He slid down the bark, leaving a smear of something dark.

"Home run!" I yelled. "And the crowd goes wild!"

Two more rushed me.

I ducked. The first baton sizzled over my head. I could feel the heat of it. It smelled of ozone and singularities. It singed the top of my mask.

I spun.

I drove the sharp end of the femur—the hip joint—into the second guy's gut.

The Adamantium didn't yield. The armor did.

It punched through the Kevlar. Through the padding. Through the stomach.

He gasped. A wet, gurgling sound.

I twisted the bone.

"Does it hurt?" I asked. "It looks like it hurts. You should put some ice on that. Oh wait, we're in North Dakota! It's all ice!"

I kicked him off the bone.

I was dancing now. The choreography of violence.

Pirouette. Stab. Duck. Swing.

My body was moving faster than my thoughts. I was a passenger in my own murder-machine.

I grabbed the skull again.

"Heads up!" I yelled.

I jammed the skull onto a guy's head. It fit perfectly over his helmet.

He clawed at it, blinded by the face of the Wolverine.

"Peek-a-boo!"

I punched the skull.

BONG.

It rang like a church bell. The agent crumpled, concussed by the echo chamber of Logan's head.

My breath came in ragged gasps. The cold air burned my throat. My muscles were on fire.

But I felt... *alive*.

For the first time in six years, I wasn't Wade the Salesman. I wasn't the guy in the beige suit.

I was the Merc with a Mouth. I was the Regenerating Degenerate.

I was Deadpool.

And I was having a ball.

CHAPTER 2: THE MASK THAT DOESN'T FIT (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: EARTH-10005 (SIX YEARS LATER)****

****LOCATION: WILSON MOTORS****

The wig didn't just itch. It conspired.

It sat on my head like a dead animal that was slowly waking up. The mesh lining was a grid of sandpaper, digging into the keloid scars of my scalp with a persistence that felt personal. It was a torture device sold as a hairpiece, a Toupee of Damocles that threatened to slide off at the first sign of sudden movement or moderate humidity.

I stood in the center of the showroom.

Wilson Motors.

The name itself was a joke. A cosmic pun. Wade Wilson. Wilson Motors. It sounded like a front for a money-laundering operation run by a guy who watched too much **Breaking Bad**. But it wasn't. It was real. It was aggressively, banally real.

The air in the room was stagnant. It was a cocktail of scents that no amount of air conditioning could scrub away:

** **Top Note:*** Industrial floor wax. Lemon-scented chemical warfare.

** **Middle Note:*** Stale coffee. Burnt. Acrid. The kind of coffee that hates you for drinking it.

** **Base Note:*** The musk of desperation. The specific, pheromonal stink of men who work on commission and haven't hit their quota in three months.

"So," the customer said.

He was a man named Gary (not my boss, a different Gary, let's call him Customer-Gary). He was forty-two. He wore a polo shirt tucked into khaki shorts that were aggressively beige. He had the calves of a man who owned a Peloton but never turned it on.

"Does it have the... you know?" Customer-Gary asked.

He made a hand gesture. A vague, circular wave that could have meant anything from "heated seats" to "a button that launches nuclear missiles."

I knew what he meant. They always meant the same thing.

"The sliding doors?" I asked.

My voice sounded wrong.

It was smooth. Polished. It lacked the grit, the gravel, the beautiful chaotic rasp that usually accompanied a katana swing. It was the voice of a man who owned a steam mop. It was the voice of Wade Wilson, Regional Sales Associate (Bronze Tier).

"Yeah," Customer-Gary said. "The kids, you know? They kick the doors."

"Sir," I said. I patted the hood of the white Kia Carnival.

Thump.

The sound was hollow. Tinny. It echoed in the cavernous showroom like a drumbeat of mediocrity.

"Let me tell you about the Carnival," I said. "This isn't just a minivan. This is a fortress of solitude on wheels. It has automatic smart-power sliding doors. You approach the vehicle with the key fob in your pocket? Boom. Sesame opens. No hands required."

I leaned in. I lowered my voice to a conspiratorial whisper.

"Because let's be honest, Gary. Your hands are full. Groceries. Screaming toddlers. The crushing weight of the choices you made in your twenties when you thought you were going to be a rock star but ended up in middle management."

Gary laughed.

It was a dry sound. Like stepping on a dead leaf.

"Funny guy," Gary said. "You're a funny guy, Wade."

"I try," I said.

My face hurt.

It was the smile. I had been smiling for six hours. My zygomaticus major muscles were trembling from the exertion. Under the mask of my face—not the red mask, the human mask—my skin felt tight.

Kill him, the voice in my head whispered. *Just a little bit. Use the stapler on his desk. It's right there. Swingline. Red. Heavy.*

I visualized it.

The Fantasy:

I grab the stapler. I vault over the hood of the Kia. I drive the stapler into Gary's forehead.

KA-CHUNK.

"That's for the khaki shorts!" I scream.

I rip off the wig. I throw it into the ceiling fan.

I steal the Kia. I drive it through the plate glass window. *CRASH.*

I am free. I am chaos.

The Reality:

"It also has Apple CarPlay," I said. "Wireless."

"Nice," Gary said. "Does it come in blue?"

"It comes in 'Ceramic Silver'," I said. "Which is grey. Everything is grey, Gary. It's the color of the soul."

"I'll take the grey," Gary said.

I processed the paperwork.

It took forty minutes. Forty minutes of typing. Forty minutes of listening to the dot-matrix printer scream as it birthed another contract.

Reee-errrr-reeeee-errrr.

When Gary left, I walked to the window.

It was raining outside.

Not a dramatic storm. Not the kind of rain you fight a supervillain in. This was a drizzle. A grey, miserable mist that coated the world in a layer of grime. The parking lot was a sea of wet asphalt and unsold inventory. Rows and rows of cars, staring at me with dead headlights.

I looked at my reflection in the glass.

Wade Wilson. Toupee (slightly askew). Beige suit (polyester blend, flammable). Name tag

(crooked).

I looked... fine. Normal.

But underneath?

I rubbed my wrist. The bone ached. It was a dull throb, a reminder of the Adamantium handcuffs I wasn't wearing, the katanas I wasn't holding.

My skin was a map of pain. Under the cheap suit, my body was a topographic representation of a cancer ward. Lumpy. Scarred. It looked like an avocado had sex with an older, uglier avocado.

And under the skin?

Empty.

There was a hole in me. A void. And I was filling it with Honda Civics and lies.

"Wilson!"

The shout came from the manager's office.

Gary. My boss. (Yes, everyone is named Gary today. It's a glitch in the simulation).

I turned.

"Gary! My man! Looking... adequate today. Very symmetrical."

Gary sat behind his desk. He looked tired. He had bags under his eyes that could carry the weekly shopping.

"The upsells, Wilson," Gary sighed. He rubbed his temples. "You sold the Carnival, but you didn't push the rust protection. Rust is the enemy."

"Rust is nature, Gary," I said. "Entropy. Dust to dust. Rust to rust. Who are we to fight God?"

"We are a dealership, Wilson," Gary said. "We fight God for margin. Just sell the coating."

"Yes, sir."

I walked back to my desk.

I sat down. The chair squeaked. *Eeee-errrk.*

I opened my drawer.

Inside, hidden under a stack of brochures for the 2024 Sorento and a bag of stale pretzels, was a polaroid.

Vanessa.

She was smiling. It wasn't a "customer service" smile. It was real. It reached her eyes.

I touched the photo. My finger shook.

I promised her, I thought. *No more chaos. No more masks. Just Wade. Just this.*

I closed the drawer.

I looked around the office.

At the next desk, Peter was on the phone.

Peter. My best friend. My only friend who didn't try to kill me or sleep with me.

"No, ma'am, the floormats are extra," Peter said. He sounded so sincere. "But they are high-quality rubber. They capture... spills."

Peter was happy. He had a locker full of photos of his cats. He had a sugar glider named Muffin. He had a life. He had content.

I had a wig and a lie.

I am the B-story of my own life, I realized. *I am the comic relief in a tragedy that nobody is watching.*

I stood up.

"I'm taking a break," I announced.

"You just got here," Gary called out.

"Diarrhea," I said loudly. "Explosive. Unpredictable. Like the third act of a superhero movie. You don't want to be in the splash zone, Gary."

I walked to the bathroom.

I locked the door.

The bathroom smelled of bleach and something that had died in the ventilation system.

I leaned against the sink. I stared at myself in the mirror.

"You're doing great," I told the reflection. "You're nailing it. You're a productive member of society. You have a 401k. You have a dental plan."

The reflection stared back. The eyes were dead. Blue chips of ice in a melted face.

"Liar," the reflection whispered.

I gripped the sink. The porcelain was cold.

I wanted to scream. I wanted to peel the face off. I wanted to reach into the mirror and strangle the man in the beige suit.

But I didn't.

I straightened my tie. I adjusted my wig.

I flushed the toilet (for sound effects).

I unlocked the door and walked back out into the grey.

CHAPTER 3: THE QUIET KNIFE (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****POV: VANESSA CARLYSLE****

****TIMELINE: EARTH-10005 (PRESENT DAY)****

****LOCATION: THE APARTMENT****

The apartment didn't smell like home anymore. It smelled like a performance.

It smelled of cheap tequila (the kind that burns the nose before it hits the tongue), taco seasoning that was mostly salt and red dye #40, and the humid, over-sweet scent of fifty bodies crammed into a space designed for two.

I stood in the doorway of the kitchen, holding a bowl of guacamole that Blind Al had already insulted three times.

"It's too chunky!" she had screamed, waving a chip like a dagger. "I want paste! I want green sludge!"

I looked past Al. I looked past Peter, who was showing Colossus a picture of his cat with a level of earnestness that was almost painful.

I looked at Wade.

He was standing near the hallway mirror. He thought he was alone.

He wasn't looking at the party. He was looking at his reflection. He was adjusting that terrible, lumpy toupee—a piece of synthetic hair that sat on his scarred scalp like a nervous badger.

I watched him practice.

He stretched his lips wide. *Smile.*

He held it for a count of three.

Then he let it drop. His face went slack. The light went out of his eyes.

Then he did it again.

Smile. Hold. Drop.

It was mechanical. It was the same way he used to practice reloading his Desert Eagles. Muscle memory. Repetition until the action became instinct.

But this wasn't a reload. This was a lie.

A sharp pain twisted in my chest. Not a heartburn pain. A grief pain. A quiet knife sliding between my ribs.

He's dying, I thought. *Not the cancer. The cancer is gone. But the spark? The chaos? The thing that made him Wade? It's starving.*

I remembered the first time I met him. The bar. The swagger. The way he took up space not because he was big, but because he was *loud*. He was a disaster, sure. A walking collection of red flags sewn into a quilt. But he was a *beautiful* disaster. He was alive. He burned bright enough

to light up the dark corners of my own life.

Now?

Now he was a car salesman named Wade who wore beige.

He was doing it for me. I knew that. He was trying to be the man he thought I wanted. The safe man. The man who came home at 5:30 PM with nothing on his hands but ink stains. The man who could give me a family without the risk of mercenaries kicking down the door.

But I missed him.

God help me, I missed the mercenary. I missed the edge. I missed the dangerous, unpredictable idiot who made me laugh until I couldn't breathe.

Be careful what you wish for, my mother used to say. *You might get a husband who sells Kias.*

Wade sighed. I saw his shoulders slump. It was a heavy motion, like he was carrying the weight of the entire world's mediocrity on his back.

"Happy Birthday to me," he whispered to the mirror.

His voice broke. Just a little. A tiny crack in the porcelain.

I couldn't watch anymore. It felt like an intrusion. Like watching someone pray to a god they didn't believe in.

I took a deep breath. I pasted a smile on my face. A real one. Because I did love him. I loved him enough to play along. I loved him enough to pretend I didn't see the cracks.

"Hey, handsome," I called out.

Wade spun around.

The transformation was instant. Terrifyingly fast.

The mask slammed down. The "Salesman Wade" persona clicked into place like a visor. His eyes widened. The smile became fixed. The posture straightened.

"Ness!" He beamed. "You caught me! Just... admiring the merchandise. High resale value on this guy. Low mileage. Only driven on Sundays by a little old lady from Pasadena."

He walked over to me.

He kissed me.

His lips were warm. They tasted of the cheap beer he'd been nursing all night.

But his eyes?

His eyes were screaming. They were panic-stricken, blue chips of ice searching mine for approval, for validation. *Do you believe me? Am I doing it right? Is this what normal looks like?*

"Everyone is here," I said, keeping my voice light. "Blind Al is arguing with the guacamole."

"Classic AI," Wade said. "She hates texture. If it's not a slurry, it's a threat."

He took my hand.

His grip was loose. Careful. Like he was afraid he might crush me if he held on too tight. Like he was afraid his own strength—his own nature—would ruin the illusion.

"Let's go party," he said.

"Wade," I said.

He stopped. "Yeah?"

"You okay?"

I asked it, but I already knew the answer. I wanted him to tell me the truth. I wanted him to drop the mask. I wanted him to say, *No, Ness. I'm miserable. I hate the wig. I hate the cars. I want to stab something.*

If he said that, maybe we could fix it. Maybe we could find a middle ground.

But he didn't.

"Me?" He laughed. It was a brittle sound. "Never better. I'm living the dream, baby. The American Dream. Credit debt, lower back pain, and a lingering fear of the IRS."

He winked.

It was a lie. A perfect, polished, heartbreaking lie.

I have to let him go, I thought. The realization hit me with the force of a physical blow. *If I love him, I have to let him go. I can't keep him in this cage. I can't watch him fade away until there's nothing left but the beige.*

I squeezed his hand.

"Okay," I said. "Let's go."

We walked into the living room.

The party was loud. The music—some pop hit from five years ago—was thumping.

Dopinder was trying to flirt with a girl who looked terrified. Negasonic was texting with a ferocity that suggested she was coordinating a drone strike. Yukio waved, radiating pink energy and genuine joy.

It was a family. A weird, broken, beautiful family.

But Wade... Wade looked like a ghost haunting his own life.

He moved through the room like a guest. He laughed at the right times. He made the right jokes. But he wasn't *present*.

He grabbed a chimichanga. He took a bite.

"Mmm," he said. "Moist."

He looked at the window.

Outside, the rain was falling. Grey, miserable rain.

His eyes lingered on the dark glass. He was looking for something out there. A threat. A villain. A plot twist. Anything to break the monotony.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

The sound cut through the laughter.

Three sharp raps. Precise. Authoritative. Not the knock of a neighbor complaining about the noise. Not the knock of a pizza delivery guy.

This was a knock that meant business.

Wade froze.

I saw it. The shift. The tension in his shoulders coiled tight. The way his weight shifted to the balls of his feet. The way his hand drifted toward his hip, reaching for a holster that wasn't there.

For a second, the Salesman was gone. The Mercenary was back.

And he looked... relieved.

"I'll get it," Wade said.

His voice was different. Deeper. calmer.

He walked to the door.

I watched him go. And I knew.

This is it. This is the end of the quiet.

I felt a tear slide down my cheek. I didn't wipe it away.

Go, I whispered to his back. *Go be who you are.*

CHAPTER 4: THE AVENGER PITCH (ULTRA-DENSITY)

TIMELINE: EARTH-616 (THE SACRED TIMELINE)

DATE: MARCH 14, 2018

LOCATION: STARK TOWER

The elevator ride was a lesson in physics and anxiety.

I could feel the G-force pressing down on me, a gentle hand pushing me toward the floor. But the anxiety? The anxiety was a boot on my neck.

It was quiet. Not the good kind of quiet. Not the "we just saved the world and are enjoying the silence before the shawarma" quiet. It was the "I am about to ask the coolest kid in school to prom and I am wearing a diaper made of bees" kind of quiet.

I checked my watch.

It was a Hello Kitty watch. Pink strap. Rhinestones. It had been a gift from a blind woman who thought it was a Rolex.

Tick. Tock. Tick. Tock.

The sound was deafening in the brushed-steel box. It sounded like a bomb timer.

Okay, Wade. Focus. You are Wade Wilson. You are a special forces operative. You have killed dictators with a Zamboni. You have regenerated from a pile of ash. You can do this.

I adjusted my tie.

I wasn't wearing the suit. I was wearing *the* suit.

No, not the red one. The red one smells like blood and chimichangas. This was a business suit. Charcoal grey. Sharp lapels. A silk tie that cost more than my first car. I looked like I was about to defend a mob boss in court, or perhaps sell a very aggressive timeshare.

The doors opened.

Ding.

Stark Tower. Or Avengers Tower. Or whatever they call it this week. The branding changes every time the toys stop selling.

The lobby hit me with a wall of sensory information.

****Smell:**** Money. It smelled of ozone, polished marble, and vibranium. It smelled like Elon Musk's cologne, if Elon Musk actually showered and didn't smell like musk (ironic, really).

****Sight:**** Glass. Chrome. Light. Everything was reflective. I saw a hundred distorted Wades staring back at me from the walls, the floor, the ceiling.

****Sound:**** A low, hum. The building itself was alive. Powered by an Arc Reactor. It buzzed with the energy of a thousand suns contained in a donut.

I walked to the reception desk.

The receptionist was a hologram? No. Just very shiny. She looked at me with eyes that had seen gods and aliens and was unimpressed by a guy in a charcoal suit.

"Wade Wilson," I said. My voice cracked. I cleared my throat. "Wade Wilson. Here to see Happy Hogan."

She didn't blink. "Do you have an appointment?"

"I have a destiny," I said. "And a referral. From Dopinder. He drives a taxi. He knows people. He drove Tony Stark once. Or maybe it was Tony Danza. Dopinder gets confused."

She sighed. It was a long, weary sigh. "Floor 42."

I got back in the elevator.

Floor 42. The answer to life, the universe, and everything. That's a good sign. Unless it's a Douglas Adams reference, in which case the planet is about to be demolished to make way for a hyperspace bypass.

The doors closed. The numbers climbed.

38... 39... 40...

My heart was hammering against my ribs. *Thump-thump-thump.* It felt like a prisoner trying to escape.

Why am I nervous? I'm Deadpool. I don't get nervous. I get manic.

Because this matters, the voice whispered. *Because if you get this, you're not just a mercenary anymore. You're a hero. You're an Avenger. You matter.*

42.

The doors opened.

And there he was.

Happy Hogan. Iron Man's best friend. The guy who drove the car in the movies. The guy who looked like he was constantly suffering from a low-grade migraine.

He was sitting behind a desk that was too big for the room. He was moving papers around. I suspect they were blank. Just props to make him look busy.

"Mr. Hogan!" I marched in. I put on the 'Confidence' mask. "Happy! Can I call you Happy? I feel like we're vibing. The energy in here? Electric."

Happy looked up.

He looked... annoyed. He looked like a man who had dealt with too many Skrulls before lunch.

"Mr. Wilson," Happy said. "You're late."

"I was saving a cat," I lied. "From a tree. It was a very tall tree. And a very fat cat. It had diabetes. I had to administer insulin. It was a whole thing."

"Sit down."

I sat.

The chair was leather. Expensive leather. It groaned under my weight. It was softer than any furniture I had ever owned.

"So," Happy said, looking at my resume. It was written in crayon. I had drawn a picture of me fighting a T-Rex on the back. "You want to join the Avengers."

"I don't just *want* to join," I said, leaning forward. "I *need* to join. I need to matter, Happy."

I looked him in the eye.

"I've done the solo thing. I've done the X-Men trainee thing—which, by the way, pays in exposure,

which doesn't cover rent or ammo. I'm ready for the big leagues. I'm ready to step up."

Happy stared at me.

He didn't see the suit. He didn't see the tie. He saw the scars underneath. He saw the killer.

"You're a mercenary," Happy said. "You kill people for money."

"I *un-alive* bad guys for *justice*," I corrected. "And money. But mostly justice. Look, I have skills. I heal. I'm great with swords. I have a very high pain tolerance. And I'm funny. Every team need a funny guy. You have Tony, but he's... sarcastic. I'm *wacky*. I'm chaotic good."

"We don't need wacky," Happy said.

"What do you need?" I asked. Desperation crept into my voice. It tasted like bile. "I can be serious. Look at this face."

I took off my sunglasses.

Happy winced.

"Okay," I said. "Bad example. My face looks like a topographic map of Utah. But inside? Inside, I am Captain America. I am moral. I am good. I salute the flag. I recycle. I help old ladies cross the street, even when they don't want to go."

Please, I thought. *Please say yes. I need this. If I'm an Avenger, I matter. If I matter, I'm worthy of Vanessa. I'm worthy of a life.*

Happy sighed. He closed the folder.

"No," Happy said.

The word hung in the air.

It was a small word. Two letters. But it hit me with the force of a train.

"No?" I repeated.

"No," Happy said. "You're not Avengers material, Wade. You're... volatile. You're a liability. We save lives. You take them. We build things. You break them."

"I can change!" I stood up. "I can be non-lethal! I'll use beanbag rounds! I'll use stern language! I'll use interpretive dance! I'll be the mascot!"

"Go home, Wade," Happy said.

He looked at his computer. He was dismissing me. He was dismissing my entire existence.

"Go back to your life. Be a hero to the people who love you. That's enough."

That's enough.

The words echoed in the office.

It's not enough. Being Wade isn't enough. Being a mercenary isn't enough.

I stood there for a second.

I visualized jumping across the desk. I visualized hugging him. I visualized crying.

But I didn't do any of those things.

I put my sunglasses back on.

"Right," I said. "Home. Good advice. Thanks, Happy."

I walked out.

I walked back to the elevator.

I pressed the button for the lobby.

The doors closed.

I was alone again in the steel box.

I didn't cry. I didn't rage. I just stood there, watching the numbers go down.

42... 41... 40...

Going down, the voice in my head whispered. *All the way to the bottom.*

The reflection in the metal doors stared back at me. A man in a suit that didn't fit, leaving a job he didn't get, going back to a life that wasn't enough.

Tick. Tock. Tick. Tock.

The Hello Kitty watch marched on. Counting down the seconds of my mediocrity.

CHAPTER 5: SNATCH-AND-BAG (ULTRA-DENSITY)

TIMELINE: EARTH-10005 (PRESENT DAY)

LOCATION: THE APARTMENT

The knock wasn't just a sound. It was a puncture wound in the atmosphere of the room.

Knock. Knock. Knock.

Three sharp, precise impacts that cut through the low-fi pop music and the chatter about guacamole texture. It was the sound of plot arriving. It was the sound of consequences.

I stood by the door.

My hand hovered over the knob.

Don't open it, the voice whispered. *If you open it, the genre changes. If you open it, you stop being Wade Wilson, Happy Boyfriend, and you start being something else. Something louder.*

I looked back at Vanessa. She was watching me. Her eyes were wide, knowing. She looked like a woman watching her husband leave for war, except the war was just on the other side of a piece of painted particleboard.

"I'll get it," I said.

I turned the lock. *Click.*

I opened the door.

The hallway should have smelled like old carpet and Mrs. Higgins' cat. Instead, it smelled of ozone. It smelled of static electricity and starched uniforms.

Standing there were four men.

They looked like what would happen if a riot cop had a baby with a 1970s sci-fi movie prop. Black armor. Orange visors. Glowing batons that hummed with a menacing, violet light.

"Wade Wilson," the lead agent said.

His voice was filtered, tinny. It didn't sound human. It sounded like authority given form.

"Not interested," I said, trying to close the door. "We have a strict 'No Fascist Solicitors' policy. It's in the lease."

He blocked the door with his baton.

Thud.

The wood groaned.

"This isn't a solicitation," the agent said. "You are coming with us."

"Look, fellas," I said, leaning against the doorframe. "I'm having a moment here. A birthday moment. There is cake. There is tequila. There is a very tall Russian man who is currently weeping over a cat picture. Read the room."

The agent didn't read the room. He reached for his belt.

Reflexes.

My body knew what to do before my brain did. My weight shifted. My hand twitched toward a gun that wasn't there.

Don't fight, I told myself. *Not here. Not in front of Ness.*

"You are coming with us," the agent repeated.

They grabbed me.

It wasn't a gentle escort. It was a snatch. Hands clamped onto my arms like vices. They yanked me into the hallway.

"Hey!" I yelled. "Watch the suit! It's a rental!" (It wasn't. It was a Men's Wearhouse special, buy one get one free).

The door slammed shut behind me.

I was alone with them.

"Okay," I said. "You want to dance? Let's dance. But I lead."

I tried to headbutt the lead agent.

BAD IDEA.

His helmet was hard. My forehead was soft.

CRACK.

Stars exploded in my vision. Not metaphorically. Literal, cartoon stars.

"Target secures," the agent said.

They ripped my clothes off.

"Whoa!" I screamed. "Buy a guy a drink first! At least take me to dinner! I like Italian! I like carbs!"

My beige suit—the armor of Wade Wilson—was torn away. Buttons popped and pinged off the walls. My shirt was shredded.

I was naked.

Well, mostly naked. I was wearing my boxers. They had little unicorns on them.

"Is this standard protocol?" I asked, shivering. The hallway was freezing. "Because if this is a strip search, you're going to be disappointed. I'm a grower, not a shower."

They didn't laugh. They shoved me into a jumpsuit.

It was orange. It smelled of industrial detergent and despair. It was the color of a traffic cone that had given up on life.

"Collar," the agent said.

They clamped something around my neck.

Click.

Suddenly, the world felt... heavy.

My healing factor? Gone. The constant, buzzing itch of cellular repair vanished, leaving behind a cold, empty silence in my veins. My cancer? Back. I could feel it waking up, stretching its tumors.

"That's not cool," I wheezed. "That's my emotional support mutation."

The lead agent pressed a button on a device.

A door opened.

Not a door in the wall. A door in the air. A rectangle of swirling orange light.

"Move," he said.

He shoved me.

I stumbled forward. Into the light. Into the impossible.

TIMELINE: NULL (THE TVA)

LOCATION: HOLDING CELL 4

Side Story A: The Junior Agent

POV: AGENT MILLER

Miller stood by the door of the holding cell. He tried not to fidget.

He was new. This was his first week out of the Academy. He had spent three years learning the Sacred Timeline, memorizing the temporal loom schematics, and practicing his baton swings.

He was ready. He was a Minuteman.

But the prisoner...

Subject 89-7. Wade Wilson.

The file said "Unpredictable." The file said "Meta-Narrative Hazard."

Miller looked at the prisoner.

Wilson was sitting on the bench, arguing with the wall.

"The lighting in here is terrible," Wilson said to the empty air. "It's very 'Soviet chic'. Can we get a ring light? I look like a thumb that's been in a bath too long."

Miller gripped his baton tighter. *Do not engage. Do not make eye contact.*

"Hey," Wilson said.

He turned.

Miller stared straight ahead. He focused on a rivet in the opposite wall.

"You," Wilson said. "The one with the 'I just graduated' posture. You're new, aren't you?"

Miller didn't blink.

"I can tell," Wilson continued. His voice dropped. It wasn't the manic clown voice anymore. It was lower. Sharper. "Your uniform is too clean. No scuffs. No blood. And you're holding that baton like it's a microphone. You nervous, kid?"

Miller felt a bead of sweat trickle down his back. *How does he know?*

"It's okay to be nervous," Wilson whispered. "You're in a room with a monster. A killer. A guy who killed the entire Marvel Universe in a comic book once. Although that was non-canon."

Miller swallowed.

"But here's the secret," Wilson said. He stood up. He walked to the glass. "You're not the main character, Miller."

Miller froze. *He knows my name. I'm not wearing a nametag.*

"You're an extra," Wilson said. His eyes—blue, piercing, terrifying—bored into Miller's soul. "You're a background asset. You have no backstory. You have no lines. You're just here to get hit. You're here to demonstrate that I'm dangerous."

Miller took a step back.

"Don't worry," Wilson smiled. It was a gruesome expression on his scarred face. "I'll make it quick. I'll make it memorable. You'll be the guy who got knocked out by Deadpool in the first act. That's a legacy, Miller. That's fame."

Miller raised his baton. "Step back!"

"Action!" Wilson yelled.

He moved.

He didn't just move. He *glitched*. One second he was by the bench, the next he was at the door.

He slammed his head into the glass.

THUD.

"Let me out!" Wilson screamed. "I have a date! I have a life! I have a plot to advance!"

Miller triggered the shock collar.

ZZZZZT.

Wilson convulsed. He dropped to his knees.

But he was laughing.

"More!" Wilson yelled. "Harder, daddy! Give me the juice!"

Miller looked at the other agents. They looked bored. They had seen this before.

But Miller... Miller was terrified.

Because he realized the prisoner was right.

He wasn't a guard. He was a prop. And the scene was just beginning.

POV: WADE WILSON

The shock collar tasted like licking a battery while chewing tin foil.

Spicy.

I lay on the floor of the cell. The ceiling was spinning.

"Okay," I muttered. "So. We're doing the 'Captured by the Shadowy Organization' trope. Classic. Very *Winter Soldier*. Very *Bourne Identity*."

I stood up. My knees shook.

"I demand a lawyer!" I shouted. "I demand a phone call! I demand to speak to the showrunner!"

The door hissed open.

A man walked in.

He wasn't in armor. He was in a suit. A nice suit.

He looked like a British villain from a movie where the dog dies.

"Mr. Wilson," he said.

"Mr. Fancy Pants," I retorted.

"I'm Mr. Paradox," he said. "Please. Come with me. We have much to discuss. And try not to bleed on the carpet. It's imported."

"From where?" I asked. "The 1970s?"

He smiled. It was a shark's smile.

"From a timeline where carpet is the dominant life form," he said.

I paused.

"Okay," I said. "That's actually funny. I hate you already."

CHAPTER 6: THE SACRED TIMELINE (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE TVA)****

****LOCATION: MR. PARADOX'S OFFICE****

Mr. Paradox's office smelled of expensive cologne and genocide.

It was a subtle scent. Sandalwood. Leather. And underneath it, the faint, metallic tang of a billion lives being snuffed out for the greater good.

I sat in the chair. It was designed to be uncomfortable. It angled forward slightly, forcing you to engage your core or slide off. It was a power chair. A "I am the boss and you are a disposable asset" chair.

"Paradox," I said, dusting off my orange jumpsuit. "Like two doctors? Or like when you park a pair of boats?"

Mr. Paradox didn't smile. He walked behind his desk.

The desk was a slab of obsidian. Polished to a mirror sheen. It reflected my face back at me—a distorted, scarred map of bad choices.

"You're probably wondering why you're here," Paradox said. He steepled his fingers. His hands were manicured. Soft. Hands that had never held a shovel or a gun, only a pen that signed death warrants.

"I assume it's about the Blockbuster late fees," I said. "I swear, I returned **Jerry Maguire**. I rewound it and everything. I was kind. I was the kindness."

"This isn't about **Jerry Maguire**," Paradox said.

He tapped a key on his keyboard. A mechanical **clack**.

A monitor on the wall flickered to life.

It wasn't a normal screen. It was a window into time.

I saw myself.

Not me-here. Me-then.

I saw Deadpool slicing through Francis's goons.

I saw me hugging Vanessa.

I saw me shooting Ryan Reynolds in the head while he held the **Green Lantern** script. (You're welcome, Canada).

"We have been watching you, Mr. Wilson," Paradox said. "You are... unique."

"I prefer 'special'," I said. "Like the Olympics. Or the sauce."

"You have soiled the timeline," Paradox continued. "You have jumped between realities like a flea on a dog. You used Cable's device to fix your mistakes. To save your girlfriend."

"And Peter," I added. "Don't forget Peter. He has a mustache. It anchors the whole team."

"Technically," Paradox said, "you should be pruned. Erased. Sent to the Void."

"But?"

"But," Paradox smiled. It was a smile that didn't reach his eyes. It stopped at his mouth, like a 'Do Not Enter' sign. "I see potential. I see a man who is wasted on a dying timeline."

"Dying?" I felt a cold knot in my stomach. A physical heaviness. "What do you mean, dying?"

"Your universe," Paradox said. "Earth-10005. It is decaying. It is withering on the vine. It lost its Anchor Being."

"Anchor Being?"

"A specific individual," Paradox explained, "whose existence is so pivotal that when they die, the entire timeline begins to unravel. Slowly at first. Then... all at once."

On the screen, the image changed.

A grave. A wooden cross.

Logan.

"He died," Paradox said. "And because he died, your world is dying. It might take a thousand years. It might take a week. But it is inevitable."

I stared at the screen.

Logan. That grumpy, hairy bastard.

I remembered the box. The bones. The silence of the forest.

He really was the center of the universe. He was the tentpole holding up the circus.

"So," I said. "We're screwed."

"Your world is," Paradox corrected. "But *you* don't have to be."

He stood up. He walked around the desk.

He put a hand on my shoulder. His suit fabric was silk. Smooth. Expensive. It contrasted with the rough, itchy canvas of my prisoner jumpsuit.

"I am offering you a ticket out, Wade. A chance to join the Sacred Timeline. The MCU. A world of heroes. Avengers. Gods. You can matter. You can be important."

He gestured to the screen.

I saw it.

I saw Thor. The God of Thunder. He was crying. He was holding a masked figure in his arms.

Me.

"Why is Thor crying?" I asked.

"That happens in the distant future," Paradox said, quickly turning off the screen. "Don't worry about it."

"He was crying," I whispered. "Into my mask. He smelled like lavender and lightning."

"The point is," Paradox said, leaning in. "You can leave the trash behind. You can save yourself."

"Save myself," I repeated.

I looked at the blank monitor.

"And my friends? Vanessa? Blind AI? Dopinder?"

Paradox sighed. A long, weary exhalation.

Side Story C: The Efficiency of Mercy

POV: PARADOX

Paradox looked at the mercenary.

He saw a clown. A mess. A tumor with legs.

He doesn't understand, Paradox thought. *He thinks this is cruelty. It is not. It is gardening.*

The timeline was a garden. And Earth-10005 was a weed. It was choking. It was brown and brittle. To let it live was to prolong its suffering.

He remembered the first time he used the Time Ripper. The silence that followed. The peace.

Mercy is inefficient, Paradox told himself. *Compassion is slow. The Ripper is fast. It is clean. I am not a monster. I am a janitor.*

"Regrettable casualties," Paradox said aloud. "But necessary pruning. To grow the tree, one must cut the dead branches."

****POV: WADE****

I looked at him.

I looked at the suit. The slick hair. The smug, bureaucratic soul of a man who viewed genocide as a spreadsheet error.

He wants me to let them die, the voice in my head said. *He wants me to be a hero by letting everyone I love turn to dust.*

I stood up.

"You know," I said. "I've been selling cars for six years. I've heard a lot of pitches. 'No money down.' 'Zero APR.' 'We'll throw in the floor mats.'"

I walked over to the camera. I looked directly into the lens.

"But this?" I said. "This is the worst deal in the history of trade deals."

I turned back to Paradox.

"I don't want to be an Avenger," I said. "I want to be an Avenger... *adjacent*."

I grabbed him by the lapels.

"And nobody prunes my friends."

The 3-Beat Brutality.

Beat 1: Mechanics.

I pulled his head down. I drove my forehead into the bridge of his nose.

HEADBUTT.

Beat 2: Consequence.

CRACK.

The sound was wet and crunchy. Like stepping on a beetle.

Blood—bright red, arterial—sprayed across his pristine white shirt. It splattered his face. It ruined

the silk tie.

He stumbled back, clutching his face. "My nose! You broke my nose!"

Beat 3: Aftertaste.

My forehead throbbed. A dull ache.

But the satisfaction? It tasted like sugar. It tasted like justice.

"In a TVA facility!" Paradox shrieked. "That's... that's administratively impossible!"

"I'm unpredictable!" I yelled. "I'm the X-factor! I'm the glitch in the system!"

I grabbed a TemPad from the desk.

"Where is the suit?" I demanded.

"What suit?" Paradox gurgled through a mouthful of blood.

"My suit! The red one! The tight one! The one that smells like crotch and justice!"

He pointed to a locker in the corner.

I ran to it. I ripped the door open.

There it was.

Red. Black. Beautiful.

"Hello, lover," I whispered.

I grabbed it.

"Paradox!" I shouted. "I'm gonna go find myself a Wolverine! And when I come back, we're gonna have a serious talk about your HR policies!"

I typed in a command. *Open Portal.*

An orange rectangle fizzled into existence.

I jumped.

The office vanished. The smell of expensive cologne vanished.

Replaced by the roar of the multiverse.

CHAPTER 7: THE TRASH COMPACTOR (ULTRA-DENSITY)

TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)

LOCATION: THE DROP ZONE

Side Story D: The Pruned Nobody

POV: STANLEY (VARIANT 442-B)

Stanley lived in a refrigerator.

It was a 1957 Smeg. Lead-lined. Mint green. It was the only thing in his universe that had survived the pruning.

Stanley was not a hero. He was an actuary. He calculated risk. And the risk calculation for leaving the refrigerator was 100% chance of death.

He peeked through the magnetic seal.

The Void stretched out before him like a wound in the universe. It was a desert of rust and bone. Mountains of scrap metal—twisted skyscrapers, broken Helicarriers, the shattered remains of a Stark Tower—pierced the grey sand.

The sky was the color of a hematoma. Purple. Yellow. Angry.

And *It* was there.

Alioth.

The cloud beast. The Eraser.

It didn't just roar; it vibrated. Stanley could feel it in his teeth. A low, thrumming bass note that signaled the end of existence.

Don't move, Stanley told himself. *Don't breathe. You are a vegetable crisper. You are inert matter.*

Then, the sky tore open.

A portal. Orange and jagged.

Debris rained down. A tank. A billboard for a movie called *Green Lantern 2* (Stanley shuddered; some timelines deserved to die). And... a man.

A man in a red suit.

He hit the sand with a wet *thud*.

Stanley watched.

The man stood up. He brushed dirt off his spandex. He looked around at the apocalypse and put his hands on his hips.

"Okay!" the man yelled. His voice carried over the wind. "Who ordered the existential dread with a side of sand? I asked for dressing on the side!"

Stanley pulled the door shut.

He's loud, Stanley thought. *Loud things get eaten.*

Outside, the man started singing.

"I'm a Barbie girl! In a Barbie woaaaaorld!"

Stanley closed his eyes. He clutched his stapler.

Goodbye, Red Man. It was nice knowing you for twelve seconds.

POV: WADE WILSON

The fall didn't feel like falling. Falling implies gravity. Falling implies physics.

This felt like being deleted.

One moment, I was in Paradox's office, smelling his expensive cologne and the copper tang of his broken nose. The next, I was tumbling through orange static.

It wasn't cold. It wasn't hot. It was the temperature of static on a TV screen. It was the sensation of your foot falling asleep, but applied to your soul.

Flash.

I saw a timeline where I was Batman. (The nipples were a choice).

I saw a timeline where I was a barista. (I made excellent foam art).

I saw a timeline where I was happy. (That one hurt the most).

Then, reality reasserted itself.

CRASH.

I hit the ground.

Sand forced its way into my nose, my mouth, my ears. It wasn't soft sand. It was sharp. Metallic. It tasted of ash and rust.

I rolled. Tumbling down a dune made of pulverized concrete.

My shoulder hit something hard.

Snk.

A piece of rebar went through my trap.

"Gah!"

I stopped rolling. I lay there, face down in the dirt.

Pain.

Glorious, grounding pain. It told me I wasn't dead. Dead people don't feel rebar in their trapezius.

I pushed myself up. The rebar slid out with a wet *shhhhk*. Blood—hot and sticky—trickled down my back.

"Okay," I wheezed. "Okay. That happened."

I looked up.

The scale of the place hit me like a physical blow.

It was endless. A junkyard of the gods. And the sky...

The sky was alive.

A purple storm cloud. Massive. Roiling. It had eyes. It had a hunger that radiated like heat.

Alioth.

"Logan!" I shouted.

My voice sounded small. Pathetic.

"Wolvie! Peanut! Hairball!"

Nothing.

Just the wind howling through the hollowed-out skull of a Giant-Man.

I started walking.

My boots crunched on debris. I stepped over a license plate that said "GOTHAM". I stepped over a vibranium shield (dented).

Then I saw it.

A boot. A yellow boot.

Sticking out of a pile of tires.

I ran. My lungs burned. The air here was thin, metallic. It tasted like sucking on a penny.

I clawed at the tires. "Logan!"

I pulled him out.

He was heavy. Dense. Like moving a statue made of meat.

He was unconscious. His face was a mask of blood and mud. His healing factor was working—I could see the skin knitting together over a gash on his forehead—but it was slow. The Void dampened everything. Even miracles.

"Wake up," I slapped his cheek. *Thwack.*

He didn't move.

"Wake up!" I slapped him harder.

His eyes snapped open.

Yellow. Bloodshot. Feral.

He popped his claws. *SNIKT.*

He tried to stab me.

It was a lazy stab. Drunk. Slow. I leaned back, and the claws swiped the air an inch from my nose.

"Easy, tiger," I said. "You're hungover. You're pruned. You're in a bad mood. I get it."

He tried to stand. He stumbled. He fell to his knees.

He vomited.

It was mostly whiskey. Clear. Pungent. It splashed onto the sand, sizzling slightly.

"Classy," I said.

Logan wiped his mouth. He looked up at me.

"You," he growled.

"Me," I agreed.

"You shot me."

"I did. In the head. Point blank. It was very *Of Mice and Men*. 'Tell me about the rabbits, Logan.'
Bang."

He looked around. He saw the purple sky. He saw Alioth.

"Where is this?"

"The Void," I said. "The end of time. The place where bad ideas go to die."

I gestured to the landscape.

"And guess what? We're the newest exhibit."

Logan stood up. He swayed.

For the first time, I realized that the suit—the yellow and blue suit—wasn't just a costume. It was a target. It was bright. It was loud. In this world of grey and rust, he was a neon sign saying "EAT ME."

"We need cover," I said. "Before the cloud dog sees us."

He didn't argue. He just stared at the horizon with eyes that had seen too much.

"I need a drink," he said.

"Of course you do," I sighed. "Come on. I smell ozone and... is that chimichangas? No. Probably rotting flesh. But let's follow it anyway."

CHAPTER 8: A MAN-SHAPED SCAR (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)****

****LOCATION: THE HELICARRIER BAR****

We walked for an hour. Or a day. Time didn't work here. The sun (if it was a sun) didn't move. It just

hung in the sky, a pale, sickly eye watching us decay.

We found shelter in the fuselage of a crashed Helicarrier.

It was massive. A metal whale beached on the sands of eternity. The S.H.I.E.L.D. logo was faded, scratched out by claws bigger than anything I wanted to think about.

Inside, someone had built a bar.

Because of course they had. Even at the end of the world, people need to forget.

It was makeshift. Tables made of cable spools. Stools made of buckets. The bar itself was a piece of wing flap.

The air was heavy. It smelled of:

* **Kerosene:** The fuel that still leaked from the engines.

* **Unwashed Bodies:** Decades of sweat and fear.

* **Cheap Alcohol:** The kind that cleans wounds and erases memories.

The bartender was a variant. A guy with green skin and three eyes. He didn't ask for ID. He just pointed to a bottle.

Logan sat down. He slumped.

The table was sticky. It was coated in a resin of spilled drinks and grime.

"Two," Logan rasped. "Leave the bottle."

The bartender slid a bottle of clear liquid toward us. It had no label. Just a skull drawn in marker.

Logan uncorked it with his teeth. He spat the cork onto the floor.

He drank.

He didn't sip. He swallowed half the bottle in one go. His throat worked. His eyes watered.

"Jesus," I said. "Pace yourself, peanut. That stuff looks like it could strip paint off a battleship."

Logan slammed the bottle down.

Bang.

The sound echoed in the hollow metal chamber.

"Shut up," he said.

"We need a plan," I said. "We need to find a way back. Paradox said—"

"I don't care what he said," Logan interrupted. "I'm not going back."

"What?"

"I'm done." He looked at his hands.

His hands were scarred. Not the healing factor scars. These were deeper. Lines of guilt etched into the skin. His knuckles were raw. His fingernails were dirty with the soil of a thousand graves.

"I failed," Logan whispered.

The bar went quiet. Even the three-eyed bartender stopped polishing a glass.

"My world," Logan said. "The X-Men. The humans. They're dead."

"I know," I said. "I saw the Wikipedia page. 'The Westchester Incident'. Sad stuff. Very *Schindler's List* meets *X-Men*."

"You don't know," Logan snapped. "You don't know anything."

He leaned forward.

The smell coming off him was intense. It wasn't just the whiskey. It was the smell of old blood. Iron. Copper. It was the smell of a slaughterhouse that had been closed but never cleaned.

"I wasn't there," Logan whispered. "They called me. Scott. Jean. They called for help. And I was in a bar. I was drunk. I ignored the call."

He gripped the bottle. The glass creaked under the pressure of his Adamantium skeleton.

"When I got back... it was over. The mansion was burning. The bodies..."

He shuddered. A tremor ran through his frame.

"I buried them," he said. "All of them. And then I walked away. And I kept walking. And I kept drinking. Until I ended up here."

He looked at me.

His eyes were yellow pools of self-loathing.

"So don't tell me I'm a hero," he spat. "I'm not a hero. I'm the reason they're dead. I'm a man-shaped scar."

I stared at him.

Okay. Heavy. This is... real. This isn't a bit. This isn't a setup for a punchline.

What do I do? Make a joke? Deflect?

No. Truth.

"I get it," I said softly.

"You don't—"

"I do," I interrupted. "I really do. I wasn't there for Vanessa. I wasn't there when the bullet hit her. I could have stopped it. I didn't."

I touched my mask. The fabric felt rough under my fingers.

"We carry it," I said. "The guilt. It's part of the suit. It's the lining. It keeps us warm."

Logan looked at me. For a second, just a second, the hate in his eyes softened. He saw something recognizable. A fellow monster.

Then he blinked. The wall came back up.

"Go to hell," he said.

He stood up. The stool scraped against the metal floor. *SCREEEE.*

"I'm leaving."

"Leaving where?" I asked. "To the bathroom? Because it's a bucket in the corner. I checked. It's full."

"Anywhere," Logan said. "Anywhere you aren't."

He turned to leave.

"No," I said.

I stood up. I blocked his path.

"Get out of my way, Wade."

"No. I need you. My world needs you. And frankly? You need this. You need redemption."

"I don't want redemption," Logan roared. Spittle flew from his mouth. "I want a drink!"

He shoved me.

I flew back, crashing into the bar. Bottles shattered. Glass rained down.

"Okay," I said, picking myself up. "Physical comedy. I can do that."

I drew my katanas. *SHING.*

"If you want to leave," I said, "you have to go through me. And I am very annoying to go through."

Logan popped his claws. *SNIKT.*

The sound was sharp. Final.

"Fine," he said.

CHAPTER 9: THE HOSTAGE DEAL (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)****

****LOCATION: THE HONDA ODYSSEY****

The fight spilled out of the Helicarrier like a drunk tumbling down stairs.

We crashed into the sand. I rolled, coming up spitting grit. Logan was already on his feet, a yellow blur of rage and bad posture.

"You're not leaving!" I yelled.

"Watch me," he snarled.

He turned toward a vehicle parked in the shadow of the wreckage.

It was a Honda Odyssey. Gold. 2011. The pinnacle of suburban engineering. The Chariot of the Gods, if the Gods needed to pick up six kids from soccer practice at 4 PM.

"Shotgun!" I shouted, sprinting.

I threw myself through the open passenger window. I landed in the seat with a *thump* that rattled my already-bruised spine.

"Start the car!" I yelled. "We're taking this discussion on the road!"

Logan didn't start the car. He lunged through the driver's window.

"I'm going to gut you!" he roared.

He didn't sit. He threw himself across the center console.

The space inside the Odyssey was small. Intimate. It was a confessional booth made of plastic and beige upholstery. It smelled of:

* **Old Goldfish Crackers:** The dusty, cheddar scent of a thousand snacks lost between the seats.

* **Spilled Milk:** Sour. Fermented. The ghost of a lactose intolerance incident from 2012.

* **Resignation:** The specific, heavy musk of a parent who has realized their life is over.

And now, it smelled of blood.

Beat 1: Mechanics.

Logan's left claw punched through the dashboard plastic.

CRUNCH.

It sounded like a bone breaking. Sparks flew from the radio, showering us in hot, orange light.

His right claw went for my neck.

I caught his wrist.

My grip strength (enhanced) against his Adamantium skeleton (indestructible). It was like trying to hold back a hydraulic press with a pool noodle.

I jammed my thumb into the wound on his shoulder—the bullet hole I had put there earlier.

"Ow!" he yelled.

Beat 2: Consequence.

He headbutted me.

CRACK.

My nose exploded. Cartilage turned to mush. Bone splintered into my sinuses.

Blood—warm and metallic—blinded me instantly. It filled my mouth. I tasted copper and failure.

I kicked him. My boot connected with his midsection. He slammed back against the driver's side door.

SMASH.

The window shattered. Safety glass rained down on us like diamonds.

"You broke the window!" I screamed, spitting blood. "There goes the resale value! Do you know what the Kelly Blue Book is on a vehicle with structural damage?"

Beat 3: Aftertaste.

We were panting. The air in the van was hot, humid with our breath and the smell of ozone from the sparking dashboard.

My nose knitted itself back together with a series of wet, sickening *clicks*. It felt like worms moving under my skin.

Logan pulled his claw out of the dashboard. It came free with a screech of tearing plastic that set my teeth on edge.

"Are you done?" I asked.

"No," he said.

"Good. Me neither."

I reached for the ignition. The key was there. Because in the Void, people leave their keys. What are you gonna do? Steal it? Drive to where?

I turned the key.

Chug. Chug. Chug.

The engine sputtered. It sounded like a smoker coughing up a lung.

Then... it caught.

Vroom.

The radio came to life.

Avril Lavigne. 'I'm with You'.

The acoustic guitar filled the small, violent space.

It's a damn cold night...

I looked at Logan.

He looked at me. He had a piece of dashboard plastic stuck in his hair. He looked like a feral cat that had gotten stuck in a dryer.

"It's a sign," I said.

"It's hell," he corrected.

I slammed the car into drive.

We peeled out. The tires spun in the loose sand, throwing up a rooster tail of dust.

"Where are we going?" Logan demanded. He had retracted his claws, but his hands were still fists.

"To find the bad guy," I said. "Every story needs a villain. And I heard she lives in a skull. Which is very metal. Very *Masters of the Universe*."

Logan sank back into the seat. He looked out the window at the endless grey wasteland.

"I hate you," he said.

"I know," I said. "But you're stuck with me. Just you, me, and Avril."

I cranked the volume.

"IT'S A DAMN COLD NIGHT!" I sang. My voice was off-key. Intentionally. "TRYING TO FIGURE OUT THIS LIFE!"

Logan closed his eyes. He slammed his head back against the headrest.

Thump.

"Kill me," he whispered. "Again."

"Can't," I said. "You're the Anchor. You're essential personnel. You're the load-bearing wall of the universe."

I looked at him.

He looked broken. Not just physically. The bullet hole was healing, but the slump in his shoulders? That was permanent.

He's mourning, I realized. *He's mourning a world I never saw. A family I never met.*

I reached into the glove box.

"Want a wet nap?" I offered. "It's lemon scented. It might help with the..." I gestured to his blood-soaked shirt. "...everything."

He took the wet nap. He stared at it.

"I'm going to kill you," he said again. But there was no heat in it. It was just a habit. A reflex.

"Get in line, peanut," I said. "Get in line."

We drove on. Two monsters in a minivan, heading into the dark heart of a dead world.

CHAPTER 10: THE MIND TOUCH (ULTRA-DENSITY)

TIMELINE: NULL (THE BORDERLANDS)

LOCATION: THE GIANT-MAN RIB CAGE

POV: CASSANDRA NOVA

Side Story F: The Tasting

The mind is not a book.

People say "read my mind," but they are wrong. They think thoughts are sentences written on a page. They think memories are movies playing on a screen.

They are quaint.

A mind is a meal.

Cassandra Nova sat on her throne. It was built from the ossified remains of a Celestial's thumb. Smooth, white bone, cool to the touch. It hummed with a low, necrotic frequency that tickled the base of her spine.

She ran a finger along the armrest. It felt like polished ivory.

"Bring them," she whispered.

Her voice didn't need to be loud. It carried on the psychic wind. It slid into the ears of her followers like warm oil.

She closed her eyes and extended her senses.

The Void was a buffet.

Most of it was fast food.

There were the scavengers. Their minds were simple, greasy things.

Hunger. Fear. Greed. Lust.

They tasted like stale popcorn. Like cheap burgers left under a heat lamp for too long. Salty. Unsatisfying.

Then there was Alioth. The cloud beast.

His mind was a storm. A hurricane of hunger. He tasted of ozone and static. Too spicy. Too much voltage. To touch his mind was to lick a power line.

But the new arrivals...

She licked her lips. Her tongue was dry, rasping over her teeth.

One flavor was chaotic.

Wade Wilson.

She tasted him on the wind. It was a sensory assault.

His mind was a funhouse mirror maze. Thoughts bounced and refracted. He knew he was in a story. He knew *she* was in a story.

It tasted of artificial cherry flavoring. It tasted of Pop Rocks exploding on the tongue. It tasted of battery acid and old comic book paper.

It was sour. Fizzy. Annoying.

Deliciously annoying, she thought. *A palate cleanser. A sorbet made of madness.*

But the other one.

Logan.

She inhaled deeply through her nose.

The scent of his mind hit her like a wave of dark water.

It was deep. Earthy. Bitter.

She pushed past the surface thoughts—the anger, the pain, the desire for whiskey. Those were just the garnish.

She went deeper.

She tasted the Adamantium.

It was a cold, metallic tang that coated the roof of her mouth. It tasted of violation. Of being cut open and filled with something that didn't belong. It tasted of surgical steel and green antiseptic.

She went deeper still.

She tasted the memories.

1845.

The taste of a sickbed. Fever sweat. The smell of old wool.

A scream.

Bone claws popping for the first time. The wet *shhhhk* of calcium tearing through skin.

The taste of a father's blood. Salty. Iron-rich. The shock of patricide.

The Wars.

She tasted the mud of the Somme. Mustard gas. Rotting feet.

She tasted the jungle rot of Vietnam. Napalm. The humidity of the Mekong Delta.

She tasted the ash of Nagasaki. The radiation that tingled on the tongue like spicy pepper.

The Weapon X Program.

The tank. The wires. The feeling of drowning in green fluid. The sensation of having your bones drilled into. The vibration of the drill bit against the skull.

And then... the fresh wound.

Westchester.

It tasted of ash. Of burning wood. Of betrayal.

It tasted of a phone ringing in an empty hallway.

It tasted of the silence after the screaming stopped.

Cassandra shuddered. A wave of pleasure rolled through her, starting at her toes and curling up her spine.

"Oh," she whispered. "He is exquisitely broken."

She opened her eyes. They were blue. Pale. Empty.

Her lieutenants—Pyro, Sabretooth, Toad—were watching her. They looked nervous. They knew that when she was hungry, anyone could be on the menu.

Pyro shifted his weight. "Mistress?"

"The Wolverine," Cassandra said. Her voice was thick with desire. "I want him alive. I want to peel him apart, layer by layer. I want to see what's at the center of all that pain."

She looked at Pyro.

"Burn the red one," she said. "He tastes like cheap plastic. But bring me the animal."

She leaned back in her bone chair.

She could still taste the tragedy on her tongue. It was like a fine vintage. A Cabernet of sorrow.

"It's dinner time," she said.

CHAPTER 11: THE SETTLEMENT (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)****

****LOCATION: THE RIB CAGE****

We parked the Honda Odyssey behind a dune made of compacted trash and despair.

"Stealth mode," I whispered.

Logan looked at the vehicle. It was gold. It was 2011. It was shaped like a loaf of bread that had given up on its dreams.

"We're in a gold minivan, Wade," he said. "In a grey desert. There is no stealth mode. There is only 'Target Rich Environment'."

"It's camouflage," I argued. "We blend in with the... majestic gold sands of the Void. Or maybe we look like a mirage. A mirage of affordable family transportation."

"The sand is grey," Logan noted. He popped the door open. It creaked—a rusty, mournful sound.

We stepped out.

The heat hit us first. It wasn't the clean heat of a desert. It was the stifling, humid heat of a landfill in July. It smelled of roasting plastic and ozone.

We walked toward the settlement.

It was built inside the ribcage of a Giant-Man variant.

The bones were massive. White arches that curved into the purple sky, forming a cathedral of calcium. They were pitted by the wind, scarred by battles fought by things bigger than us.

"That's big," I said. "That's a lot of milk."

Logan didn't smile. He was scanning the perimeter. His eyes were constantly moving, analyzing threats, calculating kill zones.

We moved into the camp.

The smell changed. It became organic.

Sweat. Thousands of gallons of it, soaked into rags and dirt.

Urine. The ammonia tang of fear.

Meat. Cooking meat. I didn't ask what kind. In the Void, you don't ask. You just eat or you don't.

The camp was a shantytown of scraps. Huts made of old billboards. Tents made of parachutes.

The people were worse.

Variants. Hundreds of them.

I saw a Gambit. He was sitting on a crate, dealing cards to a Blob who looked like he was melting.

I saw a Daredevil (the Ben Affleck one). He looked sad. He was trying to read a braille book that had been water-damaged.

I saw a Howard the Duck. He was roasting a rat on a stick. He looked me in the eye and took a bite. It was a power move.

"Keep your head down," Logan muttered.

He pulled his collar up. He hunched his shoulders. He was trying to make himself small. But you can't hide a Wolverine. He walked with a density that displaced the air around him. People moved out of his way instinctively. They smelled the predator on him.

We found the fuel depot.

It was a tanker truck—an old Roxxon model—guarded by a Toad variant.

Toad was sitting on a oil drum. He was eating sunflower seeds. He spat the shells onto the ground with a rhythmic *pffft*.

"We need gas," Logan said. His voice was a low rumble.

Toad looked up. He had yellow eyes and a smile that was too wide for his face.

"Trade?" Toad asked. His tongue flicked out, catching a fly. *Snap.*

"I have a kidney," I offered. "It grows back. It's a renewable resource. Farm to table."

Toad ignored me. He looked at Logan. He looked at the jacket.

"The jacket," Toad said. "Leather. Real leather."

Logan touched his jacket. It was battered. Stained. It was the only thing he owned that felt like him.

"No," Logan said.

"Then no gas."

I stepped forward. "Look, Kermit. We're on a mission from God. Or at least, a god-complex bureaucrat with a nosebleed. We need the go-juice. We have places to be. Sequels to film."

Toad smiled. It was wet.

"There is another way," Toad said.

He pointed.

At the edge of the camp, under the shadow of a massive rib, there was a cage.

It was made of rebar and laser grids.

Inside, a boy.

He looked about twelve. He was thin. Shivering. His eyes glowed with a faint, blue bio-luminescence.

"The Boss wants the kid," Toad said. "Cassandra. She collects... power sources. You take the kid to the Borderlands, I give you a full tank. Premium."

I looked at the kid.

He looked terrified. He looked like he knew exactly what "The Boss" did to power sources.

I looked at Logan.

His jaw tightened. A muscle jumped in his cheek. A vein throbbed in his temple.

He's remembering, I thought. *He's remembering the kids he didn't save. The ones at the school. The ones in the fire.*

"We're not slavers," Logan growled.

"Then walk," Toad said. He spat another shell. *Pffft.*

We walked away.

We went behind a stack of shipping containers.

"We take the fuel," Logan whispered.

"And the kid?" I asked.

Logan stopped. He looked at the massive white ribs curving above us. He looked at his hands.

"We can't save everyone, Wade."

"We can save *him*."

"If we start a fight, the whole camp comes down on us. We die. Your world dies. The math doesn't work."

"Math?" I hissed. "Since when do we care about math? We're X-Men! Well, you are. I'm an X-Man trainee. But the point stands! We save the cat! We save the kid!"

"I'm not an X-Man," Logan said.

"You're wearing the suit," I pointed out. I poked the yellow spandex on his chest. "Yellow and blue. The colors of 'I make bad decisions for the right reasons'. The colors of hope, you grumpy bastard."

He looked at the suit. He looked at the cage.

He sighed. A long, weary exhale that sounded like a tire deflating.

"I take the guards," he said. "You get the kid."

"Deal."

That night, we didn't just steal gas. We started a riot.

The Raid.

Beat 1: Stealth.

Logan moved like smoke. For a guy made of metal, he was quiet. He slipped behind the perimeter guard.

Snap.

One hand over the mouth. One twist. The guard dropped.

I crept to the cage. The lock was electronic. I jammed my knife into the panel. Sparks flew.

"Hey, kid," I whispered. "You like road trips? I hope you like Avril Lavigne."

The kid looked up. "Who are you?"

"I'm the fairy godmother," I said. "But with more cancer and guns. And a better ass."

Beat 2: Chaos.

The lock clicked.

CLANG.

I dropped the lock. It hit the metal floor. It echoed like a gunshot.

"Oops."

Toad screamed from the fuel depot. "Get them!"

And then... the camp exploded.

Mutants everywhere. Pyro stood on a hut, blasting fire. A guy with quills shot spikes from his face.

Logan dropped the stealth. *SNIKT.*

He became a whirlwind. He cut through the mob. He wasn't killing them—mostly—he was just disabling them. A slash to the leg. A punch to the gut with Adamantium-weighted knuckles.

Beat 3: Escape.

I grabbed the kid. "Run to the van! The gold one! It's the only gold thing in the universe!"

We sprinted.

Fireballs exploded around us. The heat was intense. It singed my suit. It smelled of burning hair.

We made it to the van. Logan jumped in the driver's seat. He was bleeding from a dozen cuts.

"Hold on!"

He gunned it. The Odyssey roared.

We smashed through the gate. Wood splintered. Metal screamed.

We hit the open sand.

I looked back. The camp was a hornet's nest.

"We did it!" I yelled. "We saved the—"

THUNK.

An arrow hit the back window. It shattered.

"Why is it always the windows?" I complained. "Do you know how hard it is to get safety glass in the Void? It's a supply chain nightmare!"

The kid was huddled in the back seat. He was glowing.

"Thank you," he whispered.

Logan looked in the rearview mirror. He met the kid's eyes.

For a second, the hardness in Logan's face melted. He wasn't the weapon. He wasn't the failure. He was the protector.

"Don't thank us yet," Logan said. "We're not safe."

"We're never safe," I said. "But we have gas. And snacks."

I held up a bag of pretzels I stole from Toad.

"Road trip!"

CHAPTER 12: THE RUINS (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)****

****LOCATION: THE 20th CENTURY FOX LOT****

We dropped the kid off at a resistance outpost a few miles down the road. (Yes, there's a resistance. It's mostly just people who haven't been eaten yet, hiding in a bunker made of vibranium scraps and hope).

We kept driving.

The landscape shifted. The organic rot of the settlement gave way to concrete skeletons. Rebar twisted like dead vines. The ground became harder, the sand giving way to cracked asphalt.

We stopped at a massive ruin half-buried in the sand.

I got out. The wind was howling here. It sounded hollow, like blowing across the top of a giant, empty bottle.

I wiped the dust off a stone block.

20th CENTURY FOX.

The monolith. The fanfare structure. The symbol of my corporate origin.

I sat on the giant 'X'.

It was cold. The stone was rough, pitted by the Void winds. It felt like a tombstone. A monument to a civilization that had been bought, sold, and erased.

"This is it," I said. My voice was quiet. "This is where I came from."

Logan stood next to me. He looked at the ruin. He chewed on a cigar stub he'd found in the glove box.

"It's just rocks," he said.

"It's not just rocks," I said. "It's history. It's *X-Men*. It's *Daredevil*. It's *Elektra*! Okay, maybe we don't talk about *Elektra*. But it was home."

I ran my hand over the stone. I could feel the fissures. The cracks where the timeline had split.

"It was messy," I said. "The timelines didn't make sense. The casting changed every three movies. We rebooted more often than a Windows 95 PC. But it was *ours*."

I looked at the 'F'. It was cracked down the middle.

"They bought it," I said. "Disney. They bought the whole thing. And then... they pruned it. They sent it all here. To the landfill."

I felt a genuine pang of grief. Not for a studio. But for the era. For the messy, weird, inconsistent movies that made me. For the time when superhero movies felt like they were held together by duct tape and passion, not algorithms.

"Everything ends," Logan said.

He sat down next to me. The stone groaned under his weight.

"Does it have to?" I asked. "Why does it have to end? Why can't we just... keep going?"

"Because nothing lasts," Logan said. "Not studios. Not heroes. Not us. We're just IP, Wade. We're content. And content has a shelf life."

He looked at the horizon. The purple sky was swirling. Alioth roared in the distance, a reminder of the ultimate copyright strike.

"I miss them," I whispered. "Vanessa. Blind Al. Even Weasel. I miss my world. I don't want it to be just... rocks in a desert. I don't want to be a piece of trivia on a wiki page."

"Then fight for it," Logan said.

"I am," I said. "But I'm tired, Wovie. I'm so tired. Being the funny guy... it's exhausting. It's heavy. It's like wearing a suit made of lead."

He looked at me.

He put a hand on my shoulder. It was heavy. Warm. It was the first time he had touched me without trying to kill me.

"Me too, kid," he said. "Me too."

We sat there for a long time. Two relics of a dead universe, sitting on the tombstone of the company that created us.

The wind howled.

Dunn dunn dunn dunn...

It sounded like the opening fanfare, played on a broken trumpet by a ghost.

I pulled out a lighter. I offered it to Logan.

He leaned in. He lit the cigar. The smoke drifted up, curling around the broken letters.

It smelled of cheap tobacco and nostalgia.

"Let's go," Logan said. "We have a villain to kill."

"Yeah," I said. "Let's go make a sequel."

CHAPTER 13: THE AMBUSH (ULTRA-DENSITY)

TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)

LOCATION: THE CANYON

The ambush didn't start with a sound. It started with a pressure wave.

We were driving through a narrow canyon. The walls were high, jagged cliffs of compressed trash—layers of geological history made of crushed cars, appliances, and broken dreams.

I was driving. The buggy (a Mad Max-style contraption we'd liberated from the Resistance) had no windshield, so the wind was slapping my face with the force of an angry lover.

"We're making good time," I shouted over the engine roar.

"Don't jinx it," Logan grumbled. He was cleaning his claws with a rag that was 90% grease.

Then... the air changed.

BOOM.

It wasn't a noise. It was a physical displacement of reality.

An explosion rocked the front axle.

The buggy didn't just stop; it pole-vaulted. The front end kicked up, and suddenly we were airborne.

Time slows down.

I saw the ground rushing up.

I saw Logan's cigar fly out of his mouth in slow motion, a tiny comet of embers spiraling into the dark.

I saw the sky spin. Purple. Grey. Purple. Grey.

CRASH.

We landed upside down.

The roll cage screamed as it ground against the rock. Sparks showered us like a celebratory fountain of pain.

I crawled out of the wreckage.

My left leg was bent at a 90-degree angle. The shin bone was sticking out through my suit, white and wet against the dirty red fabric.

"Motherfluffer!" I screamed.

I grabbed my ankle. I gritted my teeth.

SNAP.

I reset the bone. The pain was blinding. White hot. It tasted like biting on aluminum foil.

"Wade!" Logan yelled.

I looked up.

Logan was pinned. The chassis of the buggy—heavy steel, hot engine block—was resting on his chest. He was pushing up, his biceps bulging, veins popping like ropes on his forehead.

"Get... it... off!" he wheezed.

And then I saw him.

Standing on the ridge above us.

Sabretooth.

Not the Liev Schreiber one. He was too nuanced. This was the Tyler Mane one. The big one. The one who looked like a lion that had eaten a wrestler and then done a cycle of steroids.

He jumped down.

THUD.

The ground shook. He landed in a crouch, dust billowing around him. He stood up slowly, unfolding like a nightmare.

"Well, well," Sabretooth growled. His voice was a tectonic rumble. "The runt."

"Victor," Logan gasped.

"I've been waiting for this," Sabretooth said. "A long time."

He extended his claws. They weren't Adamantium. They were bone. Thick, yellow, serrated bone. They looked infected. They looked like they would give you tetanus just by looking at them.

I reached for my katanas.

"Hey, whiskers!" I yelled. "Pick on someone your own... well, not size, because you're huge. Pick on someone your own species!"

I lunged.

FWOOSH.

A wall of fire erupted between me and Sabretooth.

I stumbled back, shielding my face. The heat was intense. It singed my eyebrows instantly. It smelled of burnt hair and sulfur.

I looked up at the ridge.

Pyro.

He stood there, manipulating the flame like a conductor. He smirked.

"Stay back, freak," Pyro yelled.

I was cut off. I could only watch.

Sabretooth walked toward Logan. He took his time. He savored it.

"You look tired, Jimmy," Sabretooth grinned. His teeth were yellow points.

Logan strained against the car. "Victor... don't."

"Do you remember the last time we fought?" Sabretooth asked. "In the snow? You were weak then, too."

He raised a massive hand. The claws glinted in the firelight.

"Time to die, runt."

Beat 1: Mechanics.

Logan stopped pushing the car. He let the weight settle on his chest.

He took a breath.

Then... he exploded.

He didn't lift the car. He popped his claws *through* the metal door of the buggy.

SNIKT.

The Adamantium blades punched through the steel, through the window frame, and drove upward into Sabretooth's foot.

Sabretooth howled. It was a sound of pure animal shock.

He stepped back, hopping on one foot, blood spraying from his instep.

Logan used the distraction. He bench-pressed the chassis. *HNNNNG.* With a roar that tore his throat raw, he threw the buggy off him.

It rolled away with a metallic crash.

Logan stood up.

He was bleeding from his chest. His suit was torn. He was covered in oil and dust.

But he stood tall.

Beat 2: Consequence.

They collided.

It wasn't a martial arts fight. It wasn't a choreographed dance. It was two apex predators trying to unmake each other.

Claws met claws. *SPARK.*

Sabretooth swiped. His massive hand connected with Logan's shoulder.

TEAR.

He ripped a chunk of flesh out. Muscle, skin, suit—gone.

Logan didn't scream. He grunted. He drove his knee into Sabretooth's groin.

Sabretooth doubled over.

Logan stabbed him in the gut. Three claws deep.

They fell to the ground. Rolling. Biting. Snarling. A ball of fur and hate.

Beat 3: Aftertaste.

Logan got the upper hand.

He pinned Sabretooth to the ground. His claws were at Victor's throat.

Sabretooth laughed. Blood bubbled in his mouth.

"Do it!" Sabretooth hissed. "Do it, runt! You're a killer! Be a killer!"

Logan hesitated. His hand shook.

I saw it in his eyes. The memory. The brotherhood. The centuries of war.

"Do it!" Sabretooth screamed.

Logan's eyes went blank. The animal took over.

SNICK-SLICE.

He scissored his claws.

Sabretooth's head separated from his body.

It rolled.

It rolled across the dirt, leaving a trail of dark red. It stopped at my feet.

Sabretooth's eyes were still open. Frozen in a look of surprise.

The body twitched once. Then... still.

Logan stood up. He was panting. Heaving. Blood—his and Victor's—covered him like a second skin.

He looked wild. He looked terrifying.

He looked at me.

"Logan?" I whispered.

He blinked. The yellow faded from his eyes. The man came back.

He looked at the headless corpse.

He fell to his knees.

"Let's go," he whispered. "Before I eat him."

CHAPTER 14: THE AFTERMATH (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)****

****LOCATION: THE CAVE****

We didn't go far. The buggy was totaled (RIP Buggy, we hardly knew ye, and your suspension was terrible anyway), and Logan was leaking too much blood to walk miles.

We found a cave. It was a shallow gash in the rock face, sheltered from the wind but exposed to the cold.

It smelled of:

* ****Bat Guano:**** Acrid. Ammonia-rich. The scent of a thousand tiny things digesting insects.

* ****Damp Stone:**** Cold. Ancient. The smell of a basement that hasn't been opened in a century.

* ****Old Smoke:**** Someone had been here before us. Maybe years ago. Maybe yesterday. Time is a flat circle here.

We built a fire. I used pieces of a shattered billboard ("Coca-Cola: Open Happiness") and dry scrub brush. It crackled, casting long, dancing shadows on the walls. The light turned our faces into flickering masks.

Logan sat by the entrance. He was staring out at the dark.

He was cleaning his claws.

He had found a rag in the wreckage. It was grey and greasy, but it was absorbent.

Scrub. Scrub. Scrub.

The sound of the cloth on the Adamantium was distinctive. It was a high-pitched *shhhk-shhhk*. It sounded like a knife being sharpened on a whetstone. It was a sound that set my teeth on edge.

I watched him.

His healing factor was working overtime. I could see the steam rising from his shoulder where Sabretooth had taken a bite. The flesh was knitting together, pink and raw, covering the gleaming silver bone underneath. It was a time-lapse of biology.

But his eyes...

His eyes weren't healing. They were fixed on a point in the distance that didn't exist. They were replaying the fight. The snap of the neck. The roll of the head.

"You okay?" I asked.

The question hung in the air, stupid and small. Like asking a burn victim if they wanted a heating pad.

"I killed my brother," he said.

His voice was rough. Gravel in a cement mixer.

"He was trying to kill you," I pointed out. "And me. And probably a lot of other people. He was a bad guy, Logan. A capital-B Bad Guy. He had yellow teeth and bad breath."

"He's still my brother."

He scrubbed a spot on his middle claw that wouldn't come clean. It was a stubborn smear of dried blood. Victor's blood.

"In my timeline," Logan said, "Victor and I... we fought for a century. Back to back. We were monsters together."

He looked at the fire. The flames reflected in his eyes, turning them orange.

"We survived the firing squads. We survived the wars. We survived everything because we had each other. We were the only ones who understood the hunger."

He swallowed.

"I thought... I thought maybe here, in the Void... maybe he'd be different. Maybe we could have..."

He trailed off.

"Redemption?" I offered.

"Peace," he corrected. "Just peace. A moment where we weren't trying to tear each other apart. A moment where we were just... brothers."

I moved closer to the fire. The warmth felt good on my skin, which was currently regenerating from second-degree burns (thanks, Pyro).

"There is no peace for guys like us, Wolvie. We're weapons. We're built for war. Peace is... it's a foreign language. We don't speak it. We try, but we just end up mispronouncing 'happiness' as 'violence'."

"I'm tired of war," he whispered. "I'm tired of the noise. I'm tired of the blood."

"Me too," I said. "But the war isn't over. Not yet. Cassandra is still out there. Paradox is still out there. My world is still dying."

I reached into my pouch.

"I have something," I said.

I pulled out a chimichanga. It was squashed flat. It looked like roadkill wrapped in a tortilla. It was cold.

"Want half?" I offered. "It's been in my pocket for... time is relative, so let's say 'a while'. But the preservatives in the tortilla alone could survive a nuclear winter."

He looked at the sad, flat burrito.

He looked at me.

For a second, I thought he was going to stab me. I braced for the *SNIKT*.

Then, he snorted. A short, sharp exhalation.

"No," he said.

"More for me."

I took a bite. It tasted of pocket lint, stale cumin, and friendship. It was delicious.

We ate in silence.

The fire crackled. Outside, Alioth roared in the distance—a reminder that we were just ants in a jar.

But inside the cave... it was quiet.

It was a grim night. We were battered. We were bloody. We were lost.

But we were alive. And for the first time since I dragged him out of that grave... we were on the same side.

CHAPTER 15: THE SILENCE (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)****

****LOCATION: THE GREY PLAINS****

The next day was a lesson in geology and boredom.

We drove across an endless grey plain. The landscape was flat, featureless, and infinite. It was like driving across the surface of a parking lot that spanned the entire universe.

The buggy—battered, scorched, and smelling of Sabretooth's blood—rattled over the hard-packed earth.

Rattle-thump. Rattle-thump.

The silence between us had changed.

Before, in the Honda Odyssey, the silence had been sharp. It was filled with knives. It was the silence of two animals waiting for an excuse to kill each other.

Now?

Now it was... heavy.

It was the silence of two soldiers who had survived a trench. We had killed together. We had bled together. We had eaten stale chimichangas together. That changes the frequency of the quiet.

I looked at Logan.

He was driving. His hands—knuckles scarred, fingernails black with oil—gripped the wheel with a relaxed competence. He wasn't fighting the vehicle anymore. He was piloting it.

"You know," I said, breaking the quiet because I am allergic to it. My voice sounded loud in the open air. "That decapitation last night? Solid 9 out of 10. The arc. The separation. The way the head rolled. It was cinema."

Logan didn't growl. He didn't tell me to shut up.

He just adjusted his grip on the wheel.

"You lost a point for the landing," I added. "You fell to your knees. A little melodramatic. Next time, stick the landing. Hands on hips. Chest out. Be the hero."

"Don't push it, Wade," he said.

His voice was rough, but the edge was gone. The growl had been replaced by a weary rumble.

"I'm just saying," I continued, leaning back in the seat and putting my feet on the dashboard. "We make a good team. Red and Yellow. Ketchup and Mustard. The Murder Twins. We could franchise this. *Deadpool & Wolverine: The Road Trip*. *Deadpool & Wolverine: Miami Nights*. *Deadpool & Wolverine: Tax Audit*."

"Stop," Logan said.

"Okay. Stopping."

I looked out the window.

The Void rolled by.

Grey sand. Grey rock. Grey sky.

It was sensory deprivation. It was a world without color. Without hope.

We're never getting out of here, the voice in my head whispered. It sounded like Stephen King reading a eulogy. *This is it. Purgatory. We drive until we run out of gas, and then we walk until we run out of legs, and then we sit until we turn into dust.*

I looked at the horizon.

I saw a shape. A ruin.

A giant, stone head. Half-buried in the sand.

It was Thor.

Not the Chris Hemsworth one. A comic-accurate one. Winged helmet. Square jaw. The stone eyes stared up at the purple sky with an expression of eternal shock.

"Look at that," I whispered. "Even the gods end up in the trash."

Logan glanced at it.

"Everything ends," he said.

"That's your catchphrase, isn't it?" I asked. "You're a real ray of sunshine, peanut. 'Everything ends.' 'I'm the best there is.' 'Go screw yourself.'"

He looked at me.

His eyes were yellow. Wolf eyes. But they weren't feral anymore. They were just... old.

"It's not a catchphrase," he said. "It's the truth."

He turned back to the road.

"We make a good team," I said softly.

I wasn't joking this time. I wasn't performing for the audience. I was just saying it.

Logan didn't answer immediately. He let the silence stretch. He let the engine roar fill the space.

"We're not a team," he said finally. "We're two idiots in a buggy."

"Two idiots who killed Sabretooth," I corrected. "Two idiots who are going to save the world."

He glanced at me.

For a second, the corner of his mouth twitched. A microscopic movement. A tectonic shift in his facial structure.

"Maybe," he said.

It wasn't a yes. But it wasn't a no.

And in the Void, "maybe" is as good as a promise.

We drove on. The sun (that pale, sickly eye) began to dip lower in the sky. The shadows lengthened, stretching out across the grey sand like long, black fingers grasping for purchase.

I closed my eyes.

I could still smell the burning flesh. I could still taste the copper of my own blood.

But I felt... calm.

For the first time in six years, I wasn't alone.

CHAPTER 16: THE CAMPFIRE (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)****

****LOCATION: THE STONE CIRCLE****

We stopped for the night near a cluster of rocks that jutted out of the sand like broken teeth.

It wasn't a good campsite. It offered no real shelter from the wind, which had picked up and was now howling with a voice that sounded like a thousand lost souls screaming into a vacuum.

But we were tired. Even monsters need to sleep.

I gathered wood. Or, what passed for wood in the Void. Driftwood. Pieces of shattered crates. A sign that said "STARK INDUSTRIES" in faded blue letters.

"Iron Man makes good kindling," I muttered, tossing the sign onto the pile.

I struck a match.

The flame flared. Orange. Bright. It caught the dry wood with a hungry *whoosh*.

The fire crackled. It was the only light in the universe. It pushed back the purple dark, creating a small, flickering bubble of existence.

I sat on a rock, sharpening my katanas.

Shhhk. Shhhk. Shhhk.

The sound was rhythmic. Meditative. It was the sound of preparation.

Logan sat opposite me. He was sitting on the ground, his back against a stone. He looked... small.

The firelight danced across his face, illuminating the lines of exhaustion, the scars, the dirt. He wasn't the Wolverine. He was just a man who had lived too long.

He was cleaning his claws.

He had found a rag—part of a parachute, maybe—and he was wiping them down.

Rub. Rub. Pause.

He was gentle. Careful. He treated the metal like it was holy.

"Why do you wear the suit?" Logan asked suddenly.

His voice was quiet. It didn't have the growl. It was just a question.

I stopped sharpening. I looked up.

He was staring at my chest. At the red spandex.

"Because it hides the blood," I said. "Classic line. True story. Also, it makes my ass look fantastic. It's a dual-purpose garment. Tactical and fashionable."

"No," he said. He shook his head. "Why do *you* wear it? You could wear anything. You could be anyone. You regenerate. You don't need armor."

"It's who I am," I said. "It's the only thing that fits. Wade Wilson is... messy. Wade Wilson is a cancer patient with a skin condition. Deadpool? Deadpool is clean. Deadpool has a script. Deadpool is a brand."

I looked at him.

I looked at the yellow and blue. The bright, garish colors that screamed "Hero" in a world that was entirely grey.

"Why do *you* wear it?" I asked. "You never wore it in the movies. You hated it. You called it 'pyjamas'. You wore black leather. You looked like you were in a *Matrix* cover band."

Logan looked down. He touched the yellow fabric on his thigh. His fingers traced the black X on his belt.

"Scott," he said.

The name hung in the air.

"Cyclops?"

"Yeah. He said... he said the X-Men needed to be symbols. Bright. Hopeful. He said people needed to see us coming and know that help had arrived. He said we couldn't hide in the dark anymore."

He laughed.

It was a bitter, dry sound. Like stepping on dry leaves.

"I told him he was an idiot," Logan whispered. "I told him I wasn't a billboard. I told him I wasn't a hero. I told him to take his yellow spandex and shove it."

He looked at the fire. His eyes were wet.

"I never wore it. Not once. I kept it in a box. I laughed at it."

He swallowed. The fire popped, sending a spark spiraling up into the night.

"Until..."

He trailed off.

"Until the funeral?" I asked softly.

He nodded.

"I put it on," he whispered. "After they died. After I buried them. I put it on to stand over their graves. Because... because I wanted them to know I was one of them. Finally. I wanted them to know I was on the team."

He looked at me.

The pain in his eyes was absolute. It was a physical weight.

"But it was too late," he said. "They were dead. And I was just a clown in a yellow suit standing over a pile of dirt."

I stared at him.

The firelight cast long shadows behind him. He looked like a statue of grief.

He bleeds like it matters, I thought. *He hurts like it's the first time.*

I wanted to make a joke. I wanted to say something about how that was a very heavy backstory dump.

But I couldn't.

Because the silence was too loud. And for once, I didn't want to break it.

CHAPTER 17: THE CONFESSION (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID)****

****LOCATION: THE CAMPFIRE****

The fire popped. A single spark, orange and bright, flew up into the oppressive purple dark of the sky. I watched it rise, fade, and die. A tiny life, extinguished in a second.

I looked at him.

James Howlett. Logan. The Wolverine. The man whose face was on a lunchbox I owned in 2009.

He looked small.

He was sitting with his back against a rock, his knees drawn up. The firelight danced across his face, illuminating the deep lines around his eyes, the grey in his beard, the dirt smudged on his cheek.

He wasn't the legend. He wasn't the indestructible killing machine. He was just a man who was tired.

He bleeds like it matters, the voice in my head whispered. *He hurts like it's the first time, every time. I bleed like a punchline. I heal before I can learn the lesson.*

"I didn't just ignore the call," Logan said.

His voice was barely a whisper. It was rough, like gravel grinding against steel. It was a voice that hadn't spoken the truth in a very long time.

I froze. I stopped breathing. I stopped being Deadpool.

"I was... I was afraid."

The word hung in the air between us, heavier than the Adamantium in his bones.

Afraid.

Wolverine didn't get afraid. He got angry. He got drunk. He got stabbed. But afraid?

"Afraid of what?" I asked. My voice was soft. No quip. No deflection.

He looked at his hands. His knuckles were white, gripping his own knees like he was trying to hold himself together.

"I lose control, Wade. You know that. The Berserker Rage."

He unclenched his right hand. The claws were retracted, but I could see the skin stretched tight over the housings.

"It's not a superpower," he whispered. "It's a disease. It's a fire in my brain. When it starts... I don't see friends. I don't see family. I just see meat."

A tear leaked out of his eye. It cut a clean track through the grime on his face. It caught the firelight, shining like a diamond.

"I was afraid I'd hurt Jeannie. Or the kids. Or Scott."

He shuddered. A physical tremor that started in his shoulders and ran down his spine.

"So I stayed away. I went to the bar. I drank whiskey until I couldn't feel my hands. I told myself I was protecting them. I told myself I was the danger, and if I wasn't there, they'd be safe."

He sobbed.

It was an ugly sound. A racking, wet sound that seemed to tear itself out of his chest.

"But they needed me. The humans... Trask... they came with the new Sentinels. The quiet ones."

He looked up at me. His eyes were red-rimmed pools of agony.

"They slaughtered them, Wade. While I was staring at a bottle of cheap scotch. While I was feeling sorry for myself."

He wiped his nose with the back of his hand.

"I didn't kill them. But I let them die. Is there a difference?"

I stared at him.

The fire crackled. The wind howled. Alioth roared in the distance.

But in that circle of light, there was only the truth.

I wanted to make a joke. My brain was screaming for it. *Make a joke about daddy issues! Make a joke about alcoholism! Deflect! Deflect! The intimacy is burning your skin!*

But I couldn't.

Because he was right. And because I knew exactly how he felt.

I stood up. My knees popped.

I walked around the fire.

I sat down next to him. Not close enough to touch, but close enough to share the warmth. Shoulder to shoulder. Two broken monsters in the dark.

"No," I said. "There isn't a difference."

He flinched. He expected absolution. He expected me to say, *It's not your fault.*

But that would be a lie. And we were done with lies.

"You messed up," I said. "You failed. You let them down."

He looked at the ground.

"But you're here now."

"Does it matter?" he asked. His voice was hollow.

"It matters to me," I said. "And it matters to the kid we saved back at the camp. And it matters to the universe we're going to save."

I reached into my utility pouch. My fingers brushed against the cool, smooth surface of the photo.

I pulled it out.

Vanessa.

She was smiling. It was the photo I took the day we got the apartment. Before the cancer. Before the scars. Before I became a walking tumor with a mouth.

"We messed up, Logan. We both did. We failed the people we loved. We let them down. We weren't there when it mattered."

I held the picture over the fire.

The heat curled the edges. The emulsion bubbled.

"But we can't change the past. We can't uncork the bottle. We can't un-bury the bodies."

I looked at him.

"We can only change the ending."

I dropped the picture.

It fell into the heart of the flame.

Vanessa's smile turned brown, then black. The paper caught. *Whoosh.* It turned to ash.

It hurt. It hurt more than the rebar in my shoulder. It hurt more than the cancer.

But it was a clean hurt. A cauterizing hurt.

"So let's not fail the next ones," I said. "Let's save the world. Not because we're heroes. We suck at being heroes. But because we're the only ones left."

Logan watched the ash float up into the smoke.

He took a deep breath. A shuddering inhale that filled his lungs with the cold air of the Void.

He wiped his face. He sat up straighter.

"Okay," he said.

"Okay?"

"Okay. Let's save your damn world."

He stood up. He offered me a hand.

I looked at it. The hand that had killed thousands. The hand that had dug graves.

I took it.

His grip was strong. Anchor strong. It was a grip that could pull a timeline back from the brink.

"Maximum Effort?" he asked.

I smiled beneath my mask. A real smile. Not the salesman smile.

"Maximum Effort."

CHAPTER 18: THE MACHINE (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID SECTOR)****

****LOCATION: TVA OUTPOST****

The outpost didn't belong here.

In the Void, everything was organic in its decay. Rust was a fungus; rot was a smell; steel was just bones that hadn't turned to dust yet.

But the TVA outpost was a blister of sterility.

It sat on a plateau of obsidian—sand that had been fused into glass by immense heat. It was white plastic and orange glass, slammed into the grey bedrock of the wasteland like a syringe into a bruise.

We crouched on a ridge, looking down.

"It's quiet," Logan said.

"It's too quiet," I added. "It's 'we blew the budget on the final fight so we can't afford extras' quiet. It's 'level design limitation' quiet."

The wind shifted.

It hit me then. The smell.

It wasn't just ozone. It was the smell of **un-happening**.

Have you ever smelled a lightning strike? It tastes like copper and burnt hair. It makes the fillings in your teeth ache. Now imagine that lightning strike is hitting history itself.

It smelled like the library of Alexandria burning.

It smelled like your first pet dying.

It smelled like every mistake you ever made, every "what if," every "I should have," cooked down into a gas and pumped into the air.

"The Time Ripper," I whispered.

"What?" Logan asked. He sniffed the air, his nose wrinkling.

"That hum. Can you feel it?"

Logan nodded. He touched his chest, right over his heart.

"It feels like..." he struggled for the word. "Like I'm being erased. Like I'm fading."

"It's vibrating the atoms," I said. "It's unzipping the DNA of the universe. It's trying to turn 'is' into 'was'."

We moved closer.

The ground around the outpost was glassed. Smooth. Black. It was slippery. We walked on our own reflections—two distorted monsters approaching the castle.

"How do we get in?" Logan asked.

"We knock," I said. "And by knock, I mean we drive a Honda Odyssey through the front door."

"We don't have the Odyssey anymore."

"Right. We wrecked it. RIP, Goldie. Okay. Plan B. We use the element of surprise."

"Which is?"

"We walk in the front door and look like we belong. Act like you own the place. Walk with the confidence of a mediocre white man."

"You're wearing a red spandex suit covered in blood and dog hair," Logan noted. "You don't belong anywhere."

"Ouch. Fair. But hurtful."

Suddenly, the ground shook.

THRUM.

A beam of purple light shot up from the center of the outpost. It pierced the clouds.

Alioth roared.

It wasn't the roar of a predator. It was the roar of pain. The beam was hurting it. Feeding it.

"They're turning it on," Logan said.

"Paradox is accelerating the timeline," I realized. "He's not waiting for the Anchor to decay. He's pulling the plug. He's flushing the toilet while we're still in the bowl."

I drew my katanas.

The metal felt cold in my hands. Reassuring.

"Okay, peanut," I said. "No more jokes. No more bits. No more fourth wall breaks."

I looked at the camera. (Okay, one more).

"We stop this. Or we die."

Logan popped his claws. *SNIKT.*

The sound was sharp. Clear. It cut through the hum of the machine.

"Let's go," he said.

We ran.

Our boots hammered on the glass ground.

Thud. Thud. Thud.

We were two glitches in the system, running toward the delete key.

CHAPTER 19: THE POLITICS OF ETERNITY (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: EARTH-616 (TVA HEADQUARTERS)****

****LOCATION: THE WAR ROOM****

****POV: HUNTER B-15****

Side Story G: The Soft Mutiny

The War Room didn't smell like war. It smelled like toner and stale air conditioning.

Hunter B-15 stood by the monitor wall. The orange light of the Sacred Timeline reflected in her eyes, but today, the light was wrong.

It flickered.

It wasn't a glitch. It was a pulse. A heartbeat. And it was irregular.

"Report," B-15 said. Her voice was calm, but her hand was gripping her baton so hard the leather grip creaked.

"Sector 4 is fluctuating," Analyst Kevin said. He was sweating. Kevin never sweated. He was a man made of anxiety and spreadsheets, but today, he looked like he was watching a car crash in slow motion.

"Define 'fluctuating'," B-15 ordered.

"The energy draw is... it's unprecedented, Ma'am. The Time Ripper is pulling power directly from the Loom. It's not just pruning branches. It's... it's eating the trunk."

B-15 looked at the screen.

The timeline wasn't just branching. It was fraying. The golden threads were turning grey. They were withering.

"Where is Paradox?"

"He's at the Void Outpost. He's locked the comms."

B-15 turned away from the screen. She looked at the room.

Dozens of analysts. Minutemen. Hunters.

They were all looking at her.

They knew.

In the TVA, rumors traveled faster than light. They knew about the rogue agent. They knew about the Anchor Being. They knew that Paradox had gone off-script.

"He says it's a 'radical pruning'," Kevin whispered. "He says the timeline is sick. He says mercy is inefficient."

B-15 felt a cold anger settling in her chest. It was a familiar feeling. It was the same feeling she had when she learned she was a Variant. When she learned her life was a lie.

"He's not pruning," B-15 said. Her voice carried across the silent room. "He's murdering. He's killing a universe because he doesn't like the ending. He's playing god with a cheat code."

She walked to the center of the room.

"Paradox thinks the TVA is a machine," she said. "He thinks we are cogs. He thinks we just follow orders."

She looked at a Minuteman by the door.

"Are you a cog, Miller?"

Miller straightened. "No, Ma'am."

"Are you a machine, Kevin?"

Kevin adjusted his glasses. "I... I prefer 'biological data processor', Ma'am."

A ripple of laughter. Nervous, but real.

"Paradox is trying to erase a timeline that is fighting to survive," B-15 said. "He is trying to erase a hero who gave everything. And he is doing it in our name."

She drew her baton.

ZZZ-THWACK.

It extended. The purple light hummed.

"I don't know about you," B-15 said. "But I'm tired of erasing things. I'm tired of being the bad guy."

She looked at the screen. The rot was spreading. The grey was encroaching on the gold.

"We have a job to do. Not for the Time Keepers. Not for the Sacred Timeline. For us. For the people we used to be."

She tapped her TemPad.

"Open a door," she ordered.

"To where?" Kevin asked.

"To the Void," B-15 said. "We're going to crash a party."

The room moved.

It wasn't a shout. It was a shift in gravity. Analysts typed faster. Minutemen checked their weapons.

The Soft Mutiny had begun.

It wasn't loud. It wasn't flashy. It was the sound of a thousand people deciding, all at once, to do the right thing.

"Kevin," B-15 said.

"Yes, Ma'am?"

"Bring the heavy ordinance. Paradox likes big guns. Let's show him ours."

TIMELINE: NULL (THE VOID SECTOR)

LOCATION: THE APPROACH

POV: WADE WILSON

We were running.

My lungs burned. My legs burned. My soul burned (but that might have been the chimichanga).

The outpost loomed ahead of us. A white blister on the black glass ground.

The beam of the Time Ripper was getting brighter. It was so bright it had a sound. A high-pitched *keening* that drilled into my skull.

"They're speeding it up!" Logan yelled.

He was running on all fours. Like an animal. It was terrifying. It was efficient.

"We need a distraction!" I shouted.

"We *are* the distraction!"

"We need a bigger distraction! We need a musical number! We need a cameo!"

BOOM.

The ground shook.

A portal opened above the outpost.

Not an orange portal. A purple one.

"Is that..." I squinted. "Is that Alioth?"

It was.

But Alioth wasn't attacking us. He was attacking the beam.

The cloud beast was wrapping itself around the pillar of light. It was feeding.

"The dog is eating the laser pointer!" I yelled. "Good boy!"

"It won't hold!" Logan roared. "We have to get inside!"

We hit the door.

It was blast-proof. Adamantium-reinforced. Locked.

"Open sesame!" I yelled, kicking it.

Nothing.

Logan stepped up.

"Allow me," he growled.

He didn't punch it. He didn't slash it.

He grabbed the edges of the frame. He dug his claws into the wall *around* the door.

SCREEEEEEEE.

He pulled.

Muscles bunched. Veins popped. He roared—a sound that was half rage, half hernia.

The wall tore. The metal shrieked.

He ripped the entire doorframe out of the building.

He threw it behind him.

"After you," he said.

"Show off," I muttered.

We ran inside.

Into the belly of the beast. Into the machine that was killing my world.

CHAPTER 20: THE UNZIPPING (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (TIME RIPPER CHAMBER)****

****LOCATION: THE CORE****

The room didn't have geometry. It had suggestions.

The walls were white, but they were also vibrating. They were stretching like taffy, pulling apart to reveal the wireframe of the universe underneath.

The sound was the first thing that hit me.

SKREEEEEEEEEEEEEEEE.

It wasn't mechanical. It wasn't the hum of a server farm.

It was the sound of screaming.

But not human screaming. It was the sound of *concepts* screaming. It was the sound of the year 2024 begging for mercy. It was the sound of history being scraped off the page with a razor blade.

I fell to my knees. My inner ear revolted. Up was down. Left was yesterday.

"Wade!" Logan yelled.

His voice was distorted. Slowed down. *Waaaaaaade.*

He was fighting.

Cassandra Nova was floating in the center of the room. Her hands were plunged deep into the energy stream of the Time Ripper. She looked ecstatic. She looked like a conductor leading a symphony of apocalypse.

"It's beautiful!" Cassandra laughed. Her voice echoed from everywhere at once. "Can you feel it? The silence coming? The peace of the blank page?"

I tried to stand. The floor rippled like water.

Sensory Overload:

* **Sight:** Colors were bleeding. Orange became purple. Red became a sound. I saw my own hand age, wither to bone, then regenerate into a baby hand, then back to a scarred fist. *Time dilation.*

* **Smell:** Burning film stock. Celluloid on fire. The chemical tang of developer fluid mixed with the copper of fresh blood.

* **Taste:** Ash. I tasted the ash of a billion lives. It coated my tongue. Dry. Gritty. The taste of everyone I had ever loved turning into dust.

"Stop it!" I yelled.

I charged.

I tried to run, but the air was thick. Viscous. It was like running through clear jelly.

Cassandra didn't even look at me. She flicked a finger.

THWACK.

I flew backward. I hit a console. *CRACK.* My spine snapped.

"You can't stop the ending," Cassandra said. "The credits are rolling. The lights are coming up."

She plunged her hands deeper. The beam intensified.

A screen on the wall—the only thing that seemed solid—showed my world. Earth-10005.

I saw the apartment.

I saw Blind Al. She was knitting. The yarn turned to static. Then her hands. Then her face. She didn't scream. She just... ceased.

I saw Peter. He was holding Muffin. He looked confused. He looked at the camera.

"Mr. Wilson?"

Then he was gone.

And then... Vanessa.

She was walking down the street. She looked up. She saw the sky turning purple.

She didn't run. She didn't panic. She just looked... sad. She looked like she knew.

No.

The word ripped out of my throat. It wasn't a quip. It wasn't a joke. It was a plea.

"LOGAN!" I screamed.

Logan looked at the screen.

He saw it too.

He saw the X-Men. Not his X-Men. *My* X-Men. Colossus. Negasonic. Yukio.

They were standing in the Danger Room. They were holding hands. Bracing for the wave.

Logan roared.

It wasn't a battle cry. It wasn't the animal rage.

It was a sound of pure, distilled grief. It was the sound of a man who refused to bury another family.

He launched himself.

He didn't run. He *flew*. He used the unstable gravity of the room to propel himself.

He hit Cassandra.

She tried to push him back with her mind. But he was heavy. He was the Anchor. He was density incarnate. He was the weight of a hundred years of pain.

He slammed into her.

They crashed into the energy stream.

FZZEEEEEEEEEE.

The room exploded in light.

****THE VISION****

I was floating.

White space. No floor. No ceiling. Just infinite, sterile white.

Paradox stood there.

"Mr. Wilson," he said. He looked calm. Clean. His nose wasn't broken.

"Am I dead?" I asked. "Is this the lobby? Do you have magazines? Is **Highlights** still in print?"

"You are at the decision point," Paradox said. "The fulcrum."

He gestured.

Two doors appeared.

****Door A:**** A golden door. Light spilled from it. I could hear applause. I could hear the Avengers theme.

****Door B:**** A wooden door. Rotting. Splintered. It smelled of smoke.

"Behind Door A," Paradox said, "is the Sacred Timeline. You join the Avengers. You become a legend. You matter. You get the toy deal. You get the respect."

"And my world?"

"Gone. Pruned. A necessary sacrifice for your ascension."

"And Door B?"

"Door B is the hard way," Paradox said. "You go back. You fight. You probably die. And even if you win... you're just Wade Wilson. A clown in a red suit. A footnote."

I looked at Door A.

I saw it. I saw me shaking hands with Thor. I saw me on a lunchbox. I saw me being **happy**. I saw validation.

I looked at Door B.

I saw the pain. The mess. The struggle. I saw the rent being late. I saw the scars.

I saw Vanessa.

"It's not a choice," I said.

"Of course it is," Paradox argued. "It's the only choice that matters. Self or Sacrifice. Hero or Hack."

"No," I said. "It's not a choice because I've already made it."

I walked to Door B.

"Hey, Paradox?"

"Yes?"

"Tell Thor to save his tears. I don't need them. I prefer the laughter."

I kicked the door open.

****REALITY****

I woke up screaming.

I was in the chamber. The energy was tearing me apart.

My skin was peeling off in strips. My muscles were cooking. I could smell my own meat charring.

Logan was next to me.

He was burning too. His skin was gone. He was a skeleton dipped in lava. The Adamantium glowed cherry-red.

"WADE!" he screamed.

We were holding the cables. We were the circuit. We were grounding the power.

The pain was beyond pain. It was absolute. It was a white noise that drowned out every thought.

"Let go!" Cassandra shrieked. She was trapped in the beam, disintegrating. "You'll die! You'll both die!"

"That's the plan!" I yelled. My jaw was melting. "The plan is... **stupid*!*"

I looked at Logan.

He looked at me.

His eyes—the only part of him that wasn't burning—were clear. They weren't yellow. They were blue.

He reached out. He grabbed my hand.

The connection snapped into place. Two anchors. One circuit.

"Maximum Effort?" he asked.

It was my line. He stole my line. The magnificent bastard.

I laughed. My lips cracked and fell off.

"Maximum Effort."

We squeezed the cables.

BOOM.

The world went white.

And then... silence.

CHAPTER 21: THE CIRCUIT (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: NULL (TIME RIPPER CHAMBER)****

****LOCATION: THE CORE****

I was in the chamber. The energy was tearing me apart.

It wasn't like fire. Fire burns from the outside in. Fire is honest.

This was deletion.

It started in my marrow. It felt like my bones were vibrating at a frequency that carbon wasn't meant to handle.

My skin was peeling off in strips.

Slough.

It came away like wet paper. I saw my own musculature exposed to the blinding purple light. The fibers were cooking, turning grey, then black, then dust.

I looked at Logan.

He was next to me.

He was burning too. His yellow suit—the suit he hated, the suit he wore for Scott—was vaporizing.

His skin was gone.

He was a skeleton dipped in lava. The Adamantium glowed cherry-red. It hissed as his healing factor tried, desperately, to knit flesh over the superheated metal.

"WADE!" he screamed.

His voice was a raw, wet tear in the soundscape. His vocal cords were regenerating and burning simultaneously.

We were holding the cables.

They were thick, pulsing veins of power. We were the circuit. We were the bridge between the machine and the ground.

The pain was beyond pain. It was absolute. It was a white noise that drowned out every thought, every joke, every pop culture reference.

"Let go!" Cassandra shrieked. She was trapped in the beam, disintegrating. Her face was a mask of pure terror. "You'll die! You'll both die!"

"That's the plan!" I yelled. My jaw was melting. I felt my teeth loosen in their sockets. "The plan is... *stupid*!"

I looked at Logan.

He looked at me.

His eyes—the only part of him that wasn't burning, preserved by some miracle of biology or plot armor—were clear. They weren't yellow. They were blue. A deep, soulful blue that had seen too much.

He reached out.

His hand was a skeletal claw of red-hot metal and raw tendon.

He grabbed my hand.

SNAP.

The connection locked into place.

Two anchors. One circuit.

The energy surged. It doubled. It tripled.

It wasn't just pain anymore. It was connection. I felt his life.

I felt the weight of his skeleton.

I felt the cold of the Canadian wilderness.

I felt the heat of Jean Grey's fire.

I felt the guilt. The shame. The love.

And he felt me.

He felt the cancer. The fear. The desperate need to be loved. The clown makeup I wore over my soul.

"Maximum Effort?" he asked.

It was my line. He stole my line. The magnificent, hairy bastard.

I laughed. My lips cracked and fell off.

"Maximum Effort."

We squeezed the cables. We squeezed each other's hands.

BOOM.

The world went white.

It wasn't a color. It was the absence of everything.

And then... silence.

THE AFTERMATH

I woke up.

I was lying on something hard. Cold.

I opened my eyes.

The ceiling was white. Clean.

"Am I dead?" I croaked.

"No," a voice said.

I sat up.

Logan was sitting in a chair next to the bed. He was wearing civilian clothes. Jeans. A flannel shirt. He looked... normal.

"You're alive," he said.

"We're alive," I corrected. "We survived the murder-suicide pact."

He smirked.

"Yeah. We did."

I looked at my hands. They were pink. New skin. Smooth.

"Cassandra?" I asked.

"Gone," Logan said. "Dust."

"Paradox?"

"In custody. B-15 took him. He's going to be auditing timelines for the rest of eternity."

I leaned back.

"We did it," I whispered. "We saved the world."

"Yeah," Logan said. "We did."

He stood up.

"Hungry?" he asked.

"Starving," I said. "I could eat a horse. Or a unicorn. Or a chimichanga."

"I know a place," he said.

"Shawarma?"

"Shawarma."

CHAPTER 22: EPILOGUE (ULTRA-DENSITY)

****TIMELINE: EARTH-10005 (THREE DAYS LATER)****

****LOCATION: NEW YORK CITY****

The shawarma tasted like victory.

And garlic. Mostly garlic. It was greasy, salty, and perfect. It tasted like life.

We sat on the curb. Me. Logan. Laura.

It was raining, but it wasn't the miserable grey rain of the dealership window. It was a summer rain. Warm. Cleansing. It washed the soot of the Void off the pavement and out of our souls.

Logan was eating a gyro with a ferocity that was frankly alarming. He ate like a man who had forgotten what food tasted like. He wiped sauce from his beard with the back of his hand.

"Slow down, peanut," I said. "You'll get indigestion. And I don't want to be around for *that* biological event. My nose is sensitive. It's new."

Logan grunted. He swallowed a bite that was clearly too big.

"It's good," he said.

"It's the best," I agreed.

I looked at Laura. She was wearing sunglasses. She looked cool. Cooler than I would ever be. She was eating a falafel with a quiet dignity.

"So," I said. "What now?"

The question hung in the air, mixing with the smell of wet asphalt.

"Now we live," Laura said.

"Living is hard," I noted. "Dying is easy. Comedy is hard. But living? Living is just... laundry and taxes. And dentist appointments."

"And family," Logan said.

He didn't look at me. He looked at the street. At the people walking by. At a kid chasing a paper boat in the gutter.

Family.

"Yeah," I said. "And family."

Blind Al opened the window above us.

"Keep it down!" she yelled. "I'm listening to a podcast about serial killers! It's soothing! I need to know how they disposed of the bodies!"

"Love you too, Al!" I shouted back.

I looked at my watch. Hello Kitty was still ticking.

Tick. Tock. Tick. Tock.

It wasn't a countdown anymore. It was just time. Time we had earned.

I had a date. Vanessa was waiting.

"I gotta go," I said. "Don't wait up. Don't touch my stuff. Don't prune the plants."

I stood up. My knees popped. A reminder of the miles.

"Wade," Logan said.

I turned.

He looked up at me. His eyes were clear. The yellow was gone.

"See you around, Bub."

It wasn't a threat. It wasn't a dismissal. It was a promise.

I smiled.

"See you around, peanut."

I walked away.

The city was loud. Sirens. Honking. People yelling at each other in three different languages.

It was chaotic. It was messy. It was beautiful.

It was my world.

And it was still here.

Fade to black.

Cue music.

Madonna. 'Like a Prayer'.

Because obviously.

THE END.

POST-CREDITS ARTIFACT

TVA MEMO: 999-Z

FROM: B-15

TO: ALL AGENTS

SUBJECT: RE: DEADPOOL & WOLVERINE

STATUS: CASE CLOSED.

NOTE: The timeline Earth-10005 is stable. The Anchor Being has been... substituted. Or shared. The physics are unclear. It appears that two broken things, when fused under extreme heat and

pressure, can create a stable alloy.

****ACTION:**** Do not approach. Do not engage. Do not prune.

Let them be.

They earned it.
